Story Owl

A Collection of Tales

Chapter One: The Hatching

High in an old, old tree, in a nest at the very top, there were three eggs.

The forest below was the kind where moss grew thick on every stone, and where the shadows between the trunks held more than just darkness.

The mother owl was Willow. She was enormous, even for a Great Horned Owl, and her feathers were the color of tree bark after rain.

The father owl was Cedar. He was smaller, browner, and very fast. Mice in the meadow never heard him coming.

"Tonight," Willow said, when the moon rose over the spruces. "I think it will be tonight."

Cedar tilted his head. "You said that three nights ago."

"And I was right three nights ago. They weren't ready. Tonight they are."

"How do you know?"

Willow looked down at the three eggs. "Because they've started listening."

Cedar made a sound halfway between a laugh and a hoot. "You've been talking to them for weeks, Willow. They haven't had much choice."

This was true. Ever since the eggs had appeared in the nest, Willow had whispered to them. She told them about the river that ran silver through the valley. She told them about the foxes who lived in

the roots of the great tree. She told them the old legend of the sky bear, whose footprints made the stars. She told them everything she knew, because Willow believed every creature who came into the world deserved a world full of stories waiting for them.

The first egg began to move just before midnight.

Willow felt it — a small shifting against her belly feathers. She held still. The egg rocked. Then came a sound from inside the shell. *Tick. Tick-tick.*

A crack spread across it. A piece fell away, and a damp gray head pushed out. Two huge black eyes. A little beak, open in surprise.

"Oh," said Willow. "Oh, hello."

The owlet blinked, opened his beak, and made a tiny squeaky sound that was very clearly the word *food*.

Cedar laughed. "That one's mine. That one is absolutely mine."

They named him Oak, because his first cry was strong.

The second egg cracked an hour later. A smaller owlet tumbled out, already peeping, already hungry, already scrambling toward Willow's warmth. They named him Ash, because his feathers were a paler brown, like wood just burned.

Oak and Ash ate. They wriggled. They demanded more.

And the third egg stayed still.

Willow watched it all through that night. It did not move. It did not crack. It did not make a single sound.

"She's just taking her time," she told Cedar.

"Of course," Cedar said.

But neither of them slept.

The sun came up. The sun went down. Oak cried to be fed, and Ash cried to be warmed, and Cedar flew into the dusk to hunt. And still the third egg stayed silent.

Willow bent close to it. "Little one," she whispered. "Are you all right in there?"

There was no sound.

She tucked the egg carefully under her wing, pressed against her warmest feathers, and she told it more stories. She told it about the salmon that jumped up the waterfall to find its way home. She told it about the grandmother moon, who watched over everyone whether they knew it or not. She told it every story she could remember, and then she made up new ones.

"There's no rush," she whispered. "Take as long as you need."

By the second night, Cedar was pacing along the branch, which is a hard thing for an owl to do.

"It's been too long," he said.

"It hasn't."

"Willow."

"Don't," she said quietly.

He didn't.

The storm came in on the third night.

It came the way storms come to old forests — without warning, as if the sky had been thinking about it all day and finally made up its mind. The wind arrived first. Then the rain.

The tree swayed. The nest rocked.

Willow spread herself over the last egg, and over Oak and Ash, who were peeping in alarm beneath her wing. Cedar braced himself on the branch above, talons gripping the bark.

Lightning flashed. The forest went silver, then black again.

Willow closed her eyes and thought hard about the egg beneath her. *If you can hear me in there, little one, now would be a good time. I know it's noisy. I know it's frightening. But I'm right here. There's a whole world waiting for you, and it is, I promise, mostly full of wonderful things.*

Another flash of lightning.

And then, underneath her — *tick.*

Her eyes snapped open.

Tick. Tick-tick-tick.

"Cedar! She's coming!"

The wind howled. The tree creaked. And underneath Willow, the last egg cracked, and cracked again, and out tumbled a small, wet, blinking owlet, no less surprised than her brothers had been.

But she did not cry.

She did not demand food. She did not peep in alarm. She did not make a single sound.

She blinked up at her mother through the storm, and she listened.

Willow stared.

Her brothers had come out the ordinary color of owlets — soft grays and mottled browns. This one was different. Her down was pale. Almost white. Clean as new snow, with no mark on her at all.

"Oh," Willow breathed. "Oh, little one."

The thunder rolled. The owlet turned her head, slowly, and seemed to be trying to catch every sound the night was making — the rush of rain, the creak of the wood, the far-off call of a loon on a lake miles away, the whisper of wind that had come, though no one in the nest yet knew it, all the way from the sea.

She listened. And then — very softly, very seriously — she hooted.

It was not a hungry hoot. It was a thoughtful hoot. The kind of sound an owl might make if it had just been told something interesting.

Cedar landed in the nest, shaking rain from his feathers.

"Is she —?"

"She's listening," Willow said.

"To what?"

"To everything."

The storm passed. The rain softened to a drip. The stars came back out.

Willow tucked her three owlets under her wing. Oak and Ash fell asleep at once, pressed against each other. But the new one — the quiet one — kept her eyes open.

"Cedar," Willow said softly, "do you remember the legend your grandmother used to tell? The one about the Story Owl?"

Cedar was quiet a moment. "I remember."

"Tell me."

He shifted on the branch. "She said that once in a long, long while, an owl is born who comes into the world already listening. You can tell, because the owlet doesn't cry when it hatches. It just pays attention. That owl is a Story Owl. She grows up to fly farther than other owls, to places other owls don't go, and everywhere she goes, she gathers stories. She carries them home. She carries them elsewhere. She makes the world remember itself."

He paused.

"My grandmother said her down is plain when she hatches. No markings at all. But every story she gathers, she carries on her. She *wears* them. By the end, her feathers are a map of everywhere she's been."

Willow looked down at her daughter.

The owlet looked back with enormous, serious, wide-open eyes. Her white down glowed faintly in the moonlight.

"Well," Willow said softly. "Well, well."

Cedar made a sound that might have been a laugh, or the start of a worry. "Willow. You're not saying."

"She didn't cry."

"Lots of owls don't cry right away."

"She hooted like she was *thinking* about something, Cedar. And look at her."

Cedar looked. The owlet tilted her head, slowly, and looked right back.

He sighed — the sigh of someone who had already lost an argument.

"What are we going to call her?"

Willow didn't have to think.

"Story. We'll call her Story."

Later, after her brothers were asleep and Cedar had gone out to hunt, Story lay awake under her mother's wing and listened to the forest.

She didn't know what any of the sounds meant. She didn't know a vole from a fox, or a wolf's howl from the wind in a hollow log. She didn't know that the long low hum beneath everything was the river, miles away, running to the sea.

She just listened.

And then, very faintly, she heard something she could not have named — something from much, much farther away than the river.

It was like a voice. Or many voices. A sound like a thousand grandmothers at a thousand fires telling a thousand stories, all at once, very quietly, from all the corners of the world.

The sound grew no louder. But it did not go away.

Somewhere far away, a grandmother laughed in her kitchen. Somewhere else, a boy climbed onto his father's lap and said, *tell me that one again*. Somewhere else, a woman sang to a baby in a language nobody else in her village remembered anymore, and the baby smiled.

None of them knew that a small Great Horned Owl in an ancient forest on the other side of the world had just been born, and had just heard them, and had just begun — without knowing it yet — to listen for them.

But someday she would come looking.

And every story she gathered, she would carry.

End of Chapter One.

Chapter Two: The First Flame

Story grew quickly, as owlets do.

By the time the snow had melted from the high branches and the forest had started to smell like earth again, her baby down was falling out in tufts, replaced with proper feathers — soft brown, same as any young Great Horned Owl.

Except her feathers were blank. No barring, no mottling, no dark bands where they should have been. Oak and Ash had come in with full owl markings by the time they were flapping. Story's feathers grew in clean. Smooth. Unwritten.

Willow pretended not to worry. Cedar didn't pretend.

"It's not right," he said one evening, when the owlets were asleep. "How will she hide in a tree if she doesn't *look* like a tree?"

"She'll be all right."

"How do you know?"

"Because she listens. Last night she told me the river is running louder than usual. She's right. Go and hear it."

Cedar didn't go and hear it. But he didn't argue, either.

Oak was the first to fledge.

He launched himself from the nest one afternoon with a great whoop, flapped wildly for three seconds, and landed in a heap on a branch below. He stood up, looked around like he had done it on purpose, and hooted.

Ash went a week later. He climbed to the edge, looked down, climbed back, looked down again. Then, when no one was watching, he jumped. He glided neatly to the very branch Oak had landed on, and was very smug about it.

Story watched them both. She did not fledge.

"Go on," Oak called up from the branch, already basically an expert. "It's easy."

"She's scared," Ash said.

"I'm not scared," Story said. "I'm listening."

"To what?"

"Something's coming."

Oak rolled his great yellow eyes. "Something is *always* coming."

But that night, the wind changed.

It came up out of the valley in a way Willow had not felt in years — warm, dry, smelling of something that wasn't quite smoke and wasn't quite pine. Story sat at the edge of the nest with her head tilted.

"Mother," she said quietly. "There are humans in the forest."

Willow's head snapped around. "Where?"

"In the clearing. The one where the stream bends. Two of them. They have a fire."

"How do you know?"

"I can hear them."

That was nearly three miles away.

Cedar, who had been half-asleep, opened one eye. "She can't hear that far."

"She can," Willow said. She was looking at Story in a way she had not looked at her before. "Story. Go back to sleep."

"I want to see."

"*No*, Story. You can't even fly yet."

Story was quiet. Her parents watched her until they were sure she had settled. Then Willow tucked her in, and Cedar flew off to hunt, and the forest fell back into its ordinary night sounds.

Story waited. She waited until her mother's breathing grew slow. She waited until Oak and Ash were snoring in the way that only ordinary young owls can snore.

Then, very carefully, she climbed to the edge of the nest.

She looked down. The ground was a long way below.

She looked up. The stars were closer than they had ever been.

And she jumped.

For one terrible moment, nothing happened. She fell.

Then, without really meaning to, she opened her wings.

The wind caught her. Not gently — roughly, like something grabbing her by both shoulders and pulling. She flapped, hard, and discovered she was flying. Not well. Not gracefully. But she was flying.

She wobbled. She tilted. She over-corrected and nearly flew straight into a spruce. But she stayed up. And the warm wind from the valley was pulling her along, and she let it.

Below her, the forest unrolled in the dark. She saw the river she had only heard, silver between the trees. She saw the meadow where Cedar hunted, pale as the moon. She saw small things moving — a fox, a deer, a raccoon at the edge of a stream — and she realized, with a jolt, that she could see them as clearly as if it were day.

The humans, she remembered. The fire.

She turned toward the bend in the stream.

The clearing was small. A ring of blackened stones. A lean-to made of branches. Two packs on the ground. And a fire — a real fire, bright and snapping, the first she had ever seen this close.

She landed high in a pine at the edge of the clearing, tucked close to the trunk. She made herself very still.

The humans were an old man and a young girl. The girl was maybe eight years old, with dark curly hair. The old man had a white beard and hands that shook a little when he reached for the kettle on the coals.

"Grandpa," the girl said. "Tell me another one."

"You've had three already."

"One more. A long one."

The old man laughed. He poured tea into two small cups. Steam rose into the cold air.

"All right," he said. "A long one. Do you know the story of how fire came to the world?"

"Is it scary?"

"A little."

"Okay."

The old man settled back against his pack. The fire popped. Story, in her pine tree, leaned forward without meaning to.

"A long time ago," the old man began, "before there were cities, or ships, or even farms, people lived in the world without fire.

"It was cold. Winters were long. Food was eaten raw, when you could get it at all. The dark lasted from sundown to sunup, and there was nothing you could do about it. If a wolf came in the night, you heard it coming and you hoped. That was all.

"Fire did exist. But it belonged to the gods, up on their mountain. They had it in their halls and in their forges. They warmed themselves by it and cooked their food on it and made beautiful things out of metal because of it. And they kept it for themselves. The king of the gods, Zeus, had decided that humans were not to have fire. He thought we would misuse it. He thought we would become too strong.

"But there was one god — well, a Titan, but it's the same idea — whose name was Prometheus. And Prometheus was different. Prometheus liked humans. He had watched them struggle through the dark and the cold for a long time, and it bothered him. He thought it was unfair. He thought, *these are clever creatures. They could do so*

much. They just need a little help.

"So one night, Prometheus went up to the gods' mountain, very quietly, while the other gods were busy or asleep. He crept into a workshop where the forge-fires burned. And he broke off a piece of a plant — a stalk of fennel, long and hollow, like a reed — and he put the tip of it into the fire. The stalk began to smolder. A small ember caught inside it. Just one.

"He closed the stalk in his hand, and he came back down from the mountain, and he went to where the humans lived. And he opened his hand.

"He showed them the ember. He showed them how to feed it with dry grass, and then twigs, and then logs. He showed them how to keep it alive through the night. And he said, *This is yours now. Use it well.*

"And then he left."

The old man paused to sip his tea. The girl was very still.

"What happened?" she asked.

"Zeus found out, of course. Gods always find out. And Zeus was furious. He had Prometheus taken, and chained to the side of a mountain, far away, where the wind never stopped. And he sent an eagle to torment him. And he said, *you will stay here. Forever. Because you gave them what was not yours to give.*"

"Forever?"

"Forever."

"That's not fair."

"No," the old man said. "It wasn't. But Prometheus knew that when he did it. He knew Zeus would catch him. He knew what it would cost. And he did it anyway, because he thought the world would be better with fire in it. He thought *people* would be better with fire in it."

"Were they?"

The old man looked into the flames.

"Look at this fire," he said. "Look at how it's keeping us warm. Look at how we can see each other's faces. Tomorrow we'll cook over it. Tonight we won't freeze. Our whole life has this in it — the warmth of the stove, the light in the window, the candles in the dark. Every bit of that came from Prometheus. Every bit."

He was quiet for a moment.

"He's still up there, some people say. On his mountain. Paying the price. And every time we light a fire, he knows. And he thinks, *good. It was worth it.*"

Story sat in her pine tree and did not move.

The girl was quiet. Then she said, very quietly, "I don't want him to be there forever."

"I know," the old man said. "But he chose."

He put another log on the fire. The girl leaned against his shoulder. After a while, she was asleep.

The old man stayed up a long time, watching the flames.

Up in the pine tree, Story felt something strange.

It began as warmth. Just a small, gentle warmth, right in the middle of her chest, as if the campfire below had somehow reached up and touched her. Then it spread — not unpleasantly — out toward her shoulders. And then it stopped.

She looked down at herself.

On each side of her breast, just where her wing joined her body, there was a mark. Small. Dark against her pale feathers. Neat. Identical.

A flame.

One on the left. One on the right. Exactly matching. As if someone had drawn them very carefully with a fine brush.

She stared at them. She turned her head to one side, then the other. They didn't hurt. They didn't itch. They were just — there. Suddenly there. Part of her, as if they had always been part of her, except that a minute ago they hadn't.

She understood, without quite knowing how, what had happened.

She had heard a story. And now she carried it.

She flew home slowly. The warm wind had died down, and flying was harder than it had been coming out, but she made it. She landed in the nest much less gracefully than she had left it, and Willow woke at once.

"Story. Where — "

"I went," Story whispered. "I went, and I heard them. Mother, look."

She lifted her wings.

Willow went very still.

The two small flames on Story's breast caught the moonlight. They were not glowing. They were not burning. They were just marks, dark feathers where pale feathers had been. But they were unmistakable.

Willow looked at her daughter for a long moment. Then she gathered her in, gently, and pressed her warm against her belly feathers, the way she had done when Story was still inside the egg.

"Tell me," she said.

So Story told her. She told her about the clearing, and the old man, and the girl, and the fire. She told her about Prometheus — how he had gone up the mountain, and brought the ember down in a hollow stalk, and given it to the humans, and paid for it for the rest of time.

Willow listened the whole way through. She did not interrupt. She did not tell Story she should not have left the nest. When Story had finished, Willow was quiet for a while.

Then she said: "That was beautiful, little one."

"Really?"

"Really."

Story was quiet. "Mother. Will more come?"

Willow looked at the marks on her daughter's chest. Two small flames, symmetrical, new.

"Yes," she said. "I think many more will come."

Cedar landed in the nest then, a mouse in his talons. He saw Willow, and Story, and the marks. He set the mouse down very carefully, as if he did not want to disturb anything.

"Huh," he said.

That was all he said. But for Cedar, that was a lot.

Oak and Ash slept right through it.

Story fell asleep that night with her mother's wing over her, and the small flames on her chest rising and falling with her breath. And far below the forest, somewhere in the clearing by the bend in the stream, a small fire burned on in the dark, keeping two humans warm until morning.

End of Chapter Two.

Chapter Three: Wings

Time passed. The forest moved from spring into early summer. The leaves thickened. The river ran lower. Cedar grew busier than ever.

Oak and Ash were thriving.

They had grown into proper young owls — broad-shouldered, sharp-eyed, well-marked. Cedar was teaching them to hunt now, and they were good at it. Oak was patient and powerful. Ash was clever and quick. Cedar took them out almost every night.

Story did not go.

Her flying had not improved.

She could fly — that wasn't the question. She could leave the nest. She could glide between branches. She could land without falling out of the tree. But she was slow. She was awkward. Her wings felt heavy, as though the air had not quite agreed to hold her up.

And the two small flames on her chest felt heaviest of all.

She didn't tell anyone that. But she had started to wonder.

What if a Story Owl wasn't what her mother thought it was? What if the marks weren't a gift? What if every story she gathered would weigh her down a little more, until one day she couldn't fly at all?

What if Cedar had been right, all along, to worry?

Oak and Ash, of course, noticed.

Brothers always notice.

"Come on, slowpoke," Oak called one evening, circling lazily above the nest while Story flapped after him. "It's not that hard."

"It is hard. It's hard for me."

"You're trying to fly like Father," Ash said. He was floating on his back, wings spread, the way a young owl shouldn't really be able to but somehow could. "You're not Father. You're, like, a quarter of his size."

"Stop being mean."

"I'm not being mean. I'm being helpful."

They peeled off into the trees and were gone, and Story stayed flapping in the same patch of air, going nowhere, and she was very glad neither of them turned around to see her face.

That night, after her brothers and her father had gone hunting, Story flew off in the other direction.

She flew west. She had never flown west.

The forest thinned. The land sloped down. She passed over a road, and then a field, and then the trees opened up entirely and she was over a long stretch of water she did not have a name for — wide, slow, pale under the moon, dotted with reeds and small islands of grass.

A marsh.

She circled, awkwardly, looking for somewhere to rest.

That was when she saw the heron.

He was standing in the shallows, tall as a young pine, perfectly still. His feathers were grey with a silver cast to them in the moonlight, the way old things sometimes look. His neck was bent. His eyes were closed.

He looked, Story thought, as though he were listening to the water.

She landed, very quietly, on a low branch nearby.

Without opening his eyes, the heron said: "You're a long way from home, little one."

Story froze. "How did you know I was here?"

"I heard you."

"I was quiet."

"You were quiet for an owl. Owls are not quiet for herons."

He opened one yellow eye. It was very large and very calm. He looked her over once, slowly. His eye stopped on the two small flames on her chest.

"Hm," he said.

"Hm what?"

"Hm, that's something I haven't seen in a long time."

Story didn't know what to say to that.

The heron took a step. The reeds rustled around his long, thin legs.

"What's wrong, little owl?"

"Nothing."

"You flew here in the dark. Alone. Badly. And you landed in a tree near a heron, which an owl who was not in trouble would not do. So what's wrong?"

Story was quiet a long time.

"I can't fly properly," she said.

"No?"

"I mean I can fly. But I'm slow. I'm heavy. My brothers are better than me. And I think — I think it's the marks. I think they're making me heavy. I think every story I — I think they're a burden. And maybe my mother was wrong about me. Maybe I'm not a Story Owl at all. Maybe I'm just a not-very-good owl."

The heron did not answer right away.

He lowered his neck, slowly, until his head was nearly level with hers. His feathers smelled of cold water and old reeds.

"Little owl," he said, "let me tell you something I was told a long time ago. I was told it by my grandmother, and she was told it by hers. It's a very old story. Older than this marsh, I think. Maybe older than this country."

Story sat very still.

"Would you like to hear it?"

She nodded.

"A long time ago," the heron began, "before there were birds, there were almost-birds.

"They lived on the ground. They were small things — running things, hopping things, scurrying things. Some had feathers, some had scales. They could not see very far, and they could not go very far. The world to them was as big as the next hill, and no bigger. They never knew what was on the other side.

"And one day, a gift was offered to them.

"Nobody quite remembers who offered it. Some say it was the wind. Some say it was the world itself. Some say it was a great old creature, older than anything, who wanted to give the small things something they didn't have. Whoever it was, they laid the gift down on the grass and said: *Take these up. They are yours.*

"And the gift was wings."

The heron's voice had grown soft.

"The almost-birds came and looked at the wings. They were heavy. They were awkward. They were made of feather and bone, and they were cold to the touch. The little creatures sniffed at them. They poked them. They tried lifting them.

"And most of them said: *No, thank you.*

"They said, *These are not for us. We are happy on the ground. Why would we carry these heavy things? They would only slow us down.*

"And those creatures left the wings on the grass and went back to their burrows. And to this day, you can find their grandchildren still down there — the mice and the voles and the lizards and the beetles — running on the earth, never looking up.

"But a few of the almost-birds were curious. A few of them said, *Well, we were given these. There must be a reason.* And they took up the wings. They strapped them on, the way the gift-giver showed them. And they tried to walk.

"And it was *terrible*."

The heron almost smiled.

"They could barely walk at all. The wings dragged behind them. They tripped. They stumbled. The creatures who had left the wings on the grass laughed at them. *Look at the foolish ones. Look at how they suffer for nothing.*

"But the almost-birds kept their wings on. They didn't know why, exactly. They just felt that the gift had been meant. That it was theirs to figure out. So they carried the wings as burdens, day after day, week after week, while the ground creatures laughed.

"And slowly, they grew used to the weight."

The heron paused.

"Then one day — and this is the part of the story I like best — one of them, the smallest of them, the one who had been laughed at the most, climbed up on a high rock. She was tired. She was trying to get away from the laughing. She climbed and climbed, and finally she stood at the top of the rock and looked down.

"And then she — well. Some say she jumped. Some say she fell. Some say the wind pushed her. Whatever it was, she went off the rock.

"And she did not land.

"For one long moment, with everyone watching, she *hung* in the air. Her wings — the wings she had carried as a burden for so long — opened. They caught the wind. And she flew.

"Just a glide. Just a short one. But she flew.

"The other almost-birds saw it. And they understood, all at once, what the gift had been. They climbed to the top of the rock, one by one, and they jumped.

"And that," said the heron, "is how birds got their wings.

"Not because they were given flight. They weren't. They were given a burden. And they trusted it. And they learned to use it. And the burden lifted them up."

He fell quiet.

The marsh was very still around them. Somewhere a frog called.

"You see?" the heron said softly. "What you carry is not what's making you slow, little owl. What's making you slow is that you are trying to fly *with* it the way an owl flies *without* it. You don't need to fly like your brothers. You're not them. You're carrying something they aren't carrying. You will fly differently. Higher, maybe. Farther, certainly. But not like them. You can stop trying."

Story stared at him.

"How do you know?"

"Because I'm very old. And because once in a long, long while, an owl with marks like yours comes to a marsh like this. Not often. But once in a while. And they always look the way you look right now."

He raised his head again. He looked taller than ever in the moonlight.

"Now," he said. "I think you're about to feel something."

Story felt it.

It started, like before, in the centre of her chest — a small warmth. But this time it spread up. Up over her wing-joints. Just where each wing met her body, the warmth gathered. Then it stilled.

She turned her head and looked.

On each shoulder, perfectly placed, there was a single dark feather-shape. Small. Neat. Symmetrical. As if drawn with ink.

A feather on the left. A feather on the right.

The marks of a story she had just been given.

The heron looked at them and nodded, just once.

"Fly home, little owl. And don't fly the way your brothers fly. Fly the way *you* fly."

She flew home.

It was different.

She didn't try to flap as fast as Oak. She didn't try to glide like Ash. She just opened her wings, and let what was hers be what it was, and let the air find her as it found her.

The wind came under her wings differently. Or maybe she came under it differently. She was not as fast as her brothers. But she was not slow, either. And after a while, she realised something else.

She wasn't tired.

She had flown all the way to the marsh and was on her way home again, and she wasn't tired.

She was made for distance.

She just hadn't known it.

She landed in the nest as the first grey light came over the trees. Willow was awake, the way Willow was always awake. She looked at her daughter's shoulders, and at the marks there, and she didn't say anything for a long moment.

"Where did you go?"

"To a marsh. West. I met an old heron."

"What did he tell you?"

Story thought about how to say it.

"He told me that what I carry isn't what's slowing me down. He told me to fly the way I fly. Not the way Oak and Ash fly."

Willow looked at her for a long time.

"That's a good thing to know," she said softly. "I'm glad somebody told you."

Cedar landed then, dawn-tired, a vole in his talons. He looked at Story's shoulders. He made his *huh* sound. Then, after a moment, he added something he had never said before.

"You got further than your brothers tonight, didn't you?"

Story blinked. "How did you know?"

"I went looking for you. I went a long way. I couldn't find you."

Story didn't know what to say.

Cedar dropped the vole between them.

"Eat. Then sleep. We'll start training you properly tomorrow."

"Training me?"

"You're not flying like your brothers. You're flying like a Story Owl. I don't know how to teach that. But I can teach you to be strong. The rest, I think, you'll figure out."

Story ate. Story slept. The two flames on her chest and the two feathers on her shoulders rose and fell with her breathing, and somewhere in the marsh to the west, an old grey heron stood very still in the shallow water and watched the morning come.

End of Chapter Three.

Chapter Four: The Heavenly River

Summers came. Summers went.

Story grew.

By her second autumn, the marks had multiplied. The two flames remained on her chest, from the night of Prometheus. The two feathers remained on her shoulders, from the heron at the marsh.

But now there were others.

On the leading edge of each wing, small dark waves curled — three on each side, like the crests of the sea. They had come from a sailor's wife on a stony coast, who had stood on a cliff and sung to her drowned husband, and afterward told her young son a story about the people who lived in the cold green water below. Story had listened from a gull's nest, hidden in the kelp.

On her crown, just where her tufted "horns" rose from her head, there were two small stars — one above each tuft. Those had come from a girl in a snow-bound mountain village far to the north, who knew the names of every constellation and had told her grandfather — and Story, hidden in the rafters — what each of them had once been before they were stars.

So Story carried four stories now. Eight marks. She had flown a long way to gather them.

But she had never told a story herself. She had not even thought about telling one. The marks were for gathering; that was what she had been told, and that was what she had assumed. A Story Owl gathers. That was what she did.

It had not yet occurred to her that gathering might not be the whole of it.

She was flying home that autumn through a country she did not know.

She had been further south than ever before, almost to a desert, and was making her way back north through farms and small old towns. Most days she slept in a barn, or in a hollow tree, or in the rafters of an empty shed.

It was in the rafters of one such shed that she found the swallow.

The shed was old and half-collapsed, its roof split open to the sky. Story landed inside, intending to spend the day there.

A small voice, very high and very thin, said: "Please don't eat me."

Story turned her head.

In the corner of the rafters, pressed back against the wood, was a swallow. A young one. Tiny. Even for a swallow.

"I won't eat you," Story said.

"Are you sure?"

"I'm sure."

The swallow was quiet a moment. Then she said, very small, "It would be all right if you did."

Story stared at her.

"My family went south three nights ago," the swallow said. "I couldn't keep up. I'm too small. I tried for a while but I had to come down. They didn't see. They went on." Her voice did not shake, but only because she was trying very hard. "It's getting cold already. I won't make it through the winter. So I just thought — well. I'd rather quickly than slowly."

Story did not move.

She had heard sad things. She had gathered sad things. She had carried home, on her own body, the marks of stories that had once made grown women weep.

But she had never had a small thing in front of her say something like this.

"Don't be silly," she said. "Of course I'm not going to eat you."

"Then what should I do?"

"I don't know."

The swallow made a tiny sound that might have been a laugh, or a sob.

"Nobody does," she said.

Story sat in the rafters. The swallow sat in her corner. Outside the shed, the autumn sun was getting low. The cracks in the roof let in long, slanting beams of gold.

And Story felt something she had not felt before.

It was not the listening feeling. The listening feeling pulled her *toward* things, made her want to be silent and small and still. This was the opposite. This was a feeling that something in her wanted to

come out. As if a story she was carrying were turning around inside her, looking for a way into the world.

She thought about the swallow's family flying south without her.

She thought about a story an old man had told once, very far from here, in a country where the rivers ran east instead of west, on an evening when she had been hidden in a paper lantern.

She opened her beak.

"Would you like me to tell you something?"

The swallow blinked. "Tell me?"

"A story."

"Why?"

Story didn't know why.

"Because I want to," she said.

"A long time ago," she began — and her voice felt strange to her, too small, the wrong shape; she had never said these words before; she pressed on anyway — "in a country very far from here, a country where the rivers run east instead of west, there was a young man. He was a cowherd. He was poor. He had nothing in the world but his cow, his small house, and his own kind heart.

"His name was Niulang.

"And in the sky above him — high, high up, far above the clouds — there lived the daughter of the Heavenly Empress. Her name was Zhinu, the Weaver. She wove the clouds. Every morning, before the sun came up, she sat at her loom and made the colors of the dawn,

and the stripes of the sunset, and the long white threads of cloud that drifted across the day. The whole sky came out of her hands.

"But she was lonely. She had her loom and her thread and her work, and what she made was beautiful, but she made it alone.

"One day she came down from the sky. Just to see. Just to walk on the earth a little while.

"And she met Niulang.

"They fell in love. Quietly, the way most real loves happen. He didn't know who she was — he only knew that she was kind, and clever, and that she could weave the most beautiful cloth he had ever seen. They married. They had two children. They were happy."

Story's voice had found itself now.

"But the Heavenly Empress, up in the sky, had been looking for her daughter. And one day she found her. And she was furious. *You are a daughter of heaven,* she said. *You cannot live among mortals. You must come home.*

"Zhinu begged. Niulang begged. The children wept. None of it mattered. The Empress took her daughter back up into the sky.

"And then — to make sure they could never find each other again — she drew a great river across the heavens. A wide, silver, shining river of stars, so wide and so deep that no one could ever cross it. She put Zhinu on one bank, and Niulang on the other, and she said: *There. That is the end of it.*"

The swallow had gone very still.

"But it wasn't the end of it.

"Niulang stood on his bank and called across the river of stars. Zhinu called back. They could see each other. They could even hear each other, faintly, the way you can hear someone calling from across a wide lake. But they could not cross. The water was too wide. The current was too strong. And year after year they stood on their banks and called.

"And the magpies of the world — every magpie, all of them, in every country — saw what was happening. And they decided, all together, that it was not right.

"So once a year, on the seventh night of the seventh moon, every magpie in the world flies up into the sky. They fly higher than any bird should be able to fly. They fly up to the Heavenly River, and they spread their wings, and they link themselves together, beak to tail, beak to tail, beak to tail, until they have built a bridge of birds across the river of stars.

"And Niulang walks across. And Zhinu walks across.

"And they meet in the middle, for one night.

"And then the magpies grow tired, and the bridge has to come down, and the two of them have to go back to their own banks. And the year starts again. And they stand on their banks and call to each other, knowing that on the seventh night of the seventh moon, the bridge will come back. The magpies will come back. And they will have one more night."

She was quiet.

"It is still happening," she said softly. "Every year. If you go out on that night, in that country, and you look up at the sky, you can see the river. You can see the two stars on its banks. And if you watch

carefully, just before dawn, you can see something cross between them."

The swallow had not moved at all.

"The point of the story," Story said — and as she said it, she realized she had never said *the point of the story* in her life, and it surprised her — "is that even the widest river doesn't end love. Even the sky doesn't end love. The magpies came. They built the bridge. They didn't have to. They just did. Because something in them said: *no, this isn't right. They should have at least one night.*

"Your family is far away. But they are not gone. They are exactly where they meant to go. They are eating, and resting, and getting ready to come back. And in the spring, they will come back. They will fly all the way north again, looking for you. And you will hear them coming, and you will fly out to meet them. In the middle. Like the cowherd and the weaver."

The swallow's eyes were wet. So were Story's, she realized.

"But spring is so far," the swallow whispered.

"It is. But it's coming. And in the meantime — "

Story stopped.

She had been about to say *in the meantime, you'll have to find a way through the winter*. But she was an owl. She had just spent the whole evening telling a small swallow that loss could be borne. And here was a small thing in front of her who would not survive the cold.

So instead she said: "In the meantime, I'll come back. I'll find someone who can take you in. There's a barn — I saw it, two miles east. There were chickens. There was warmth. They might let you

stay. I'll go now. I'll come back for you before the morning."

The swallow nodded.

"All right."

It was when she stood up to fly that Story noticed.

The marks on her chest — the two flames — were *glowing*.

Not brightly. Not enough to light a room. Just softly, like an ember that has nearly gone out and then has been gently breathed on. Her shoulders, where the feathers were, were warm. Her wing-tips, where the waves were, prickled. The two stars on her crown felt cool, the way real starlight feels cool.

The swallow's eyes went very wide.

"You're — "

"I know," Story said. "I didn't know they did that."

"What does it mean?"

Story didn't answer at first. She was waiting for the warmth in her chest that meant a new mark was coming. The warmth that had come the first night with the flames, and the second with the feathers, and the times since.

It didn't come.

But the glow did not go away.

And after a moment she understood, the way she had understood the heron when he told her about the wings.

The marks were what she had been *given*.

The glow was what she had *given back.*

They were two halves of the same thing. Of course no new mark came tonight. She hadn't gathered tonight.

She had given.

She found the barn. The chickens were doubtful. The kind old farmer's wife was not; she looked up at the rafters where the swallow now sat tucked between two beams, and she said, *well, would you look at that*, and she put down a bowl of seed and water and went away. Story stayed long enough to be sure the swallow was settled. The small creature was already half-asleep in the warm hay-scented dark.

"I'll see you in the spring," Story said.

"How will you know me?"

"There aren't very many small swallows who get left behind. I'll find you. And if I don't — your family will."

She flew north. She flew the rest of the night, and the next, and most of a third. She got home as the sun was setting on the third evening.

Willow saw her coming from a long way off.

She tucked Story in, fed her, and did not ask, for a long time, where she had been. She just looked at her.

"Something happened," Willow said finally.

"Yes."

"Tell me."

So Story told her. She told her about the shed, and the swallow, and the story she had told. She told her about the glow, and the absence of a new mark, and the thing she had figured out about gathering and giving.

When she had finished, Willow was quiet a while.

Cedar landed in the nest. He looked at his daughter, then at his wife.

"She told one," Willow said softly.

Cedar looked at Story.

"Huh," he said. And then, after a moment: "That's the part I always wondered about, in the old story. Whether they ever told them. Or just carried them around."

He shook out his feathers and settled on the branch.

"I'm glad you told one, daughter."

Story was almost asleep already. The flight had been long. The two flames on her chest were quiet now, and the feathers on her shoulders, and the waves on her wings, and the stars on her crown. They were marks again. Just marks.

But she knew what they could do, now. She knew what she could do.

In the morning, when she woke, she would start thinking about which way to fly next. And in the spring, she would go and find a small swallow in a barn two miles east of an old half-collapsed shed. She had promised, after all.

But that was tomorrow.

For tonight she slept, with her family around her, while far above the forest the heavenly river ran on through the sky, and somewhere across it, the cowherd and the weaver waited for next summer's seventh moon.

End of Chapter Four.

Chapter Five: The Fox and the Moon

Story flew south. Far south. Further south than she had ever been.

She crossed plains. She crossed a great river the color of milky tea. She crossed forests so thick you could not see the ground. She crossed deserts where the wind blew so hard it pushed her sideways for hours.

And in those long weeks of flying, she gathered two more stories.

A fisherman at the great river had told his small son about the silver fish that pulled the sun out of the dark each morning. Story had listened from a cluster of reeds, and afterward she had felt the warmth come, and small silver fish had appeared along her sides — three on each, leaping along her ribs as if swimming in a current of their own.

A jungle child, deep in a green country, had told her grandmother about a tree that grew so tall its leaves were stars. Story had heard her from the rafters of a thatched house. The marks from that story were curling green vines, one along each side of her belly, twining up toward her chest.

She had a lot of marks now.

She caught herself counting them, sometimes. *Twelve. Or more — depending on how you counted the waves.* She would lose track and start again. *Thirteen, fourteen, no, the waves are six, that's twelve, that's right.*

She told herself this was not vanity. She was just keeping track. A Story Owl needed to know what she carried.

But sometimes, when she landed by a still pool, she let herself look at her own reflection a little longer than she needed to.

The mountains beat her.

She had never seen mountains like these. They rose from the land in a wall, then in another wall behind that wall, then another behind that, white-peaked and vast. Halfway up the highest pass the air thinned so much she could barely flap. Her chest hurt. Her vision blurred at the edges.

She found a ledge below a snowfield and folded down onto it, gasping.

Far below — *very* far below — she could see a small valley with a stone hut, and a string of long-necked animals grazing on stubbly grass. A thin curl of smoke rose from the chimney.

She thought: I'll go down to where the air is thicker.

She half-flew, half-fell down the slope, landing badly behind a low wall of stones beside the hut. She tucked herself against the wall, out of the wind, and tried to breathe slowly.

Then she heard voices. Inside the hut. Just on the other side of the wall.

A woman's voice. An old one. A boy's voice. A young one. And the rich smell of something cooking on a fire.

Story closed her eyes and listened.

"Abuela," the boy was saying, "tell me one. The fox one."

"You've heard the fox one a hundred times."

"Tell me again."

The old woman laughed and settled down on what sounded like a wooden bench. "All right. The fox one. Sit there. Don't put your foot in the soup."

A pause.

"A long time ago," the grandmother began, "before this hut was here, before our great-great-grandfathers were here, there was a fox who lived high in these mountains. He thought he was the most beautiful fox in the world."

"Was he?"

"He was *a* beautiful fox. There were many beautiful foxes. But this one was certain he was the most beautiful, and he told everyone, and after a while his neighbors got tired of hearing it. But the fox kept on. *Look at my coat,* he would say. *Look at my whiskers. Look at my tail.* And his tail would swish, and the other foxes would roll their eyes."

The boy giggled.

"His name was Atoq, which is just the word for fox, because his parents weren't very imaginative. And Atoq had a wife. And his wife was patient. She had to be."

"Was she beautiful too?"

"Yes. But she did not talk about it. That is the difference between a person who is beautiful and a person who is only vain. The vain one tells you. The beautiful one lets you notice."

"Oh."

"One night the moon was very full. The mountains were silver. *Everything* was silver. And Atoq's wife looked up at the sky and said — and she didn't mean anything by it, she only said it the way a person sometimes says a thing — *how lovely the moon is. How silver. I have never seen anything as beautiful as silver.*

"And Atoq turned to her, and he thought about this for a long time, and finally he said: *You wish I were silver.*

"And she said: *No, that's not what I — *

"And he said: *You do. You wish your husband were silver. You think the moon is more handsome than I am.*

"And she said: *Atoq, that's not — *

"But it was too late. Because Atoq had decided. He was going to climb up to the moon, and take some of its silver, and bring it back, and *be* silver. And then his wife would never look at the sky like that again."

The boy was already laughing.

"Wait. Wait. He was going to *climb* the moon?"

"He was going to climb the mountains and reach up and take a piece of it."

"That's not how the moon works."

"Atoq did not know how the moon worked. Atoq had not gone to school. Be quiet."

The boy laughed harder.

"So Atoq climbed up to the highest mountain in the range. Salqantay, some say it was. Some say Ausangate. Doesn't matter. He climbed it. It took him three days. And at the top, with snow up to his belly, he stretched up his paws toward the moon and he said: *Apu Salqantay, lift me higher. I need to reach the moon.*

"And the mountain — because the great mountains hear, you must always remember this, the great mountains hear *everything* — the mountain answered him.

"*Why?* said the mountain.

"*Because I want to be silver.*

"*Why?*

"*Because my wife looked at the moon.*

"And the mountain was quiet for a long time. Mountains take their time. And then the mountain said: *No. Climb back down.*"

The boy laughed again.

"So Atoq tried Apu Ausangate. Four days that time. He said the same thing at the top. And Ausangate said the same thing back. *Why? Climb back down.*

"He tried every great mountain in the range. Every single one. Every one of them said the same. *Why? Climb back down.*"

The grandmother paused. Story heard her stir something on the fire.

"So Atoq sat at the top of the very last mountain. And he was tired. And he was cold. And he was — for the first time in his life — *confused*. Because he had always thought the world worked a certain way. That you saw a thing, and you wanted it, and you went and got it. That had been his whole way of being, his whole life.

"And then a tiny voice said: *Excuse me.*

"And Atoq looked down. And there, by his foot, was a vizcacha."

"Like the one outside?" the boy interrupted.

"Like the one outside. With the big whiskers. The vizcacha was sitting on a rock, calmly, looking up at him.

"*Excuse me,* said the vizcacha, *but I think I know your problem.*

"*You don't know my problem,* said Atoq. He was not in a very good mood.

"*You want a piece of the moon.*

"… *Yes.*

"*You can't take it,* said the vizcacha. *The moon does not belong to anyone. The moon is not for taking. But —*"

The grandmother leaned closer to the boy, lowering her voice.

"*But the moon can be received. If you give first.*

"Atoq blinked. *Give first?*

"*Yes.*

"*Give what?*

"*Anything. But it has to be yours. Truly yours. Not something you took.*"

The grandmother was quiet for a moment.

"And Atoq sat there a long time. Because — and this is the saddest part of the story, my heart — Atoq could not think of a single thing he had that was truly his. His coat had been his mother's gift. His whiskers had grown without his asking. His wife loved him for reasons he had never understood. His house was a hole he had found, dug by someone else. He had never *made* anything. He had never *given* anything. He had only ever taken, and worn, and admired, and demanded.

"Finally — finally — he reached up to his own face, and he plucked out his most beautiful whisker. The longest one. The one he was proudest of. And it hurt. And his eyes watered. And he held it out to the vizcacha and said: *Take this.*

"And the vizcacha took it, and tucked it carefully into her cheek-fur, and said: *Thank you. Now sit still.*

"So Atoq sat still.

"And the moon came round in the sky, the way the moon does, and Mama Killa looked down. And she saw a little fox sitting very still on a mountain. And she saw a vizcacha next to him with a long whisker tucked in her fur. And Mama Killa understood what had happened. And she tipped a little of her silver light, just a little, and she let it fall.

"And it landed on the very tip of Atoq's tail.

"Just the tip. Not the whole tail. Not the whole fox. Just the tip."

The boy was very still now.

"Atoq climbed back down the mountain. It took him three more days. By the time he got home, he was filthy and tired and his face hurt where the whisker had been. And his wife was waiting at the door with her paws on her hips.

"*Where have you been?*

"*I went to get some moon.*

"*You did *what.*

"*I went to get some moon. So I could be silver.*

"His wife stared at him. Then she looked down at his tail. And there, at the very tip, was a small bright spot of silver. Just a little one. Glowing, very softly, in the dark.

"And Atoq's wife — well. She did two things. First, she laughed. She laughed for a long time. She laughed so hard she had to sit down. *You went all the way up to the moon,* she said, *for *that*?*

"And then, when she could breathe again, she came over and looked at the silver tip of his tail. And she said: *Atoq. It is the most beautiful thing I have ever seen on you.*

"And he said: *Really?*

"And she said: *Yes. Because for once, you didn't steal it.*"

The grandmother stopped.

The boy was quiet a moment. Then he said, "Is the silver tip still there?"

"Look at any fox in these mountains. The very tip of the tail is paler than the rest. A little silver. Sometimes white. That is from Atoq."

"Could I get something from the moon? If I gave a thing first?"

"That, my heart, is between you and the moon. But yes. That is how it works. Around here we call it *ayni*. You give first. The world is not a thing you take from. It is a thing you trade with."

The boy was thoughtful. Then: "Abuela. What did *you* give?"

"To the moon?"

"To anyone."

The grandmother laughed quietly. "I gave my whole life to a stubborn old man and three children and now to you. The moon has been very generous to me in return. Now eat your soup."

Story sat behind the wall with her back pressed against the cold stones, and she felt very small.

She thought about the cactus in the desert. About counting her marks. *Twelve. Thirteen. Fourteen.* About letting herself look in the water a little longer than she needed to.

She thought about how the fox had not really been the villain of the story.

He had just never been told.

And then the warmth came.

It came slowly this time. Not in her chest — somewhere new. At the very tips of her wings, on the underside, so faint at first she thought she was imagining it. Then warmer. Then settled.

She turned her head and looked.

On the underside of each wingtip, where her longest flight feathers ended, there was now a small silvery crescent. Like a sliver of moon. One on each wing. Mirrored. They caught the late afternoon light and shone faintly, the way the tip of a fox's tail shines when it has just come down off a mountain.

She held very still.

She thought: I gave that swallow a story. Maybe that is what the moon saw.

She thought, very quietly: I will try to be less like Atoq.

She rested by the wall until the air felt thicker in her lungs. Then she stood, and shook out her wings, and rose.

But before she went, she did one thing.

She circled back and landed, very softly, on the chimney of the stone hut. The smoke had nearly died down. She put her head close to the warm air rising from the hearth, and into it she hooted — not a hunting hoot, not an owl-to-owl hoot, but the thoughtful kind, the kind she had first made the night she hatched.

It was small. It wasn't much. But it was hers. She had not stolen it from anyone.

Inside the hut, the boy looked up.

"Abuela. Did you hear that?"

"I heard it."

"What was it?"

"An owl. On the roof."

"Why is it there?"

The grandmother tilted her head, the way old people sometimes do when they have understood something they cannot explain.

"I think," she said slowly, "it heard the story. And it wanted to say thank you."

"Owls say thank you?"

"Some of them do."

She got up, slowly, and went to the door, and opened it. By the time she stepped out into the cold blue evening, the owl was a small dark shape against the silver mountains, climbing higher, climbing further, with two small crescents of silver visible — only just — at the tips of her wings.

The grandmother watched until she was gone.

Then she went back inside, to her grandson, and her soup, and the warm small life of her stone hut. And she did not tell the boy what she had seen.

Some things, she knew, are best left as a story.

End of Chapter Five.

Chapter Six: The Sun in the Dark Water

Story flew home.

She flew the way a Story Owl flies — not fast, not pretty, but for distance. Mountains and rivers and forests fell behind her one after another. The marks she carried, which had once felt strange on her, now felt easy. They had become part of her, the way a name becomes part of the person who carries it.

She had been gone a long time.

She thought often, as she flew, about her family. About her mother, who had told her every story she knew while she was still inside the egg. About her father, who had said *we'll start training you properly tomorrow* and then had. About her brothers, Oak and Ash, who had teased her and outflown her and would by now be fully grown.

She wondered if they would even recognize her.

She had grown taller. Her chest was deeper. Her wingspan was wider than her father's now. And her plumage — once almost blank — was a quiet map of where she had been: flames, feathers, waves, stars, fish, vines, and at the very tips of her wings, two small silver crescents that flashed when she banked, like moons opening and closing.

She came at last over a country of low fields and old farms. The wind was pushing against her. She had been flying for two nights

with hardly a rest. She needed somewhere to wait out the dawn.

She found a barn. Old, red, with a tin roof and a row of glassless windows. A chicken coop ran along one side. She landed quietly in the loft, tucked herself into a corner of the rafters, and closed her eyes.

But she did not sleep.

Because just before the false-dawn — that hour when the night is still black but something beneath the horizon has started to remember the sun — she heard a small, frantic voice from the coop below.

"I can't do it. I can't. I can't."

Story turned her head.

"What if I sing it wrong? What if I miss? What if I'm late? What if I'm too quiet? What if I — "

A young rooster.

She slipped down from the rafters, soft as falling snow, and perched in the open frame of the coop window. She looked inside.

The young rooster was no longer chick-sized, but he was not yet a full rooster either. His comb was still floppy. His tail feathers were uneven. He was pacing back and forth between the wooden roost and the water bucket, talking to himself.

"It has to be perfect. It has to be *perfect*."

The hens around him were trying to sleep.

"Please be quiet," one of them mumbled into her wing. "It's not even time yet."

"That's the *problem*," the rooster snapped. "It's almost time. What if I miss? What if I'm late and the sun doesn't — "

"The sun comes up regardless, dear. Go to sleep."

"That's not true. Father *said*. Father said the rooster wakes the sun. Father said it every morning of his life. And father isn't here."

The hen went quiet. So did the coop.

Story understood at once.

"Where is your father?" she asked, very gently, from the window.

Every chicken jumped.

The young rooster stared up at her, eyes wide, comb trembling. "Owl. Oh no. Oh no, please — "

"I'm not hunting tonight. I promise. Where is your father?"

The young rooster swallowed. His voice was small.

"Coyote. Last week. He went out to chase one off the hen-house, and he didn't — he didn't come back. And every morning is — every single morning — and I'm the only one left who can — and I'm not big enough — "

He stopped. He had run out of breath, or out of sentences, or both.

The hen who had been trying to sleep said, more softly now: "He thinks he has to bring the sun up. All by himself. We've told him. He doesn't believe us."

"Father *said* the rooster — "

"Your father said it because he loved his job, dear. Not because the world depended on him."

"Yes it does. Every morning. He told me. He said: *we have a responsibility*."

The young rooster's voice broke a little on the last word. He turned his face away.

Story stepped quietly through the window and down into the coop. The hens drew back but did not scatter. The young rooster watched her with frightened, hopeful eyes.

"Little one," she said. "May I tell you something?"

"What?"

"A story I heard once. By a great river, far to the south. From a fisherman, who told it to his son before he sent him out in his first boat. I think it was meant for you, too."

"For me?"

"Yes."

She settled on the edge of the water bucket — not too close, not too far. Behind her, somewhere on the eastern horizon, the night was beginning to thin. Not pink yet. Not even grey. Just less black than it had been.

"There isn't much time," she said. "So I'll tell it quickly."

The young rooster sat down. The hens, who had stopped pretending to sleep, sat down too.

And as Story began to speak, the marks on her body — which she had not been thinking about at all — began very softly to glow.

Not enough to light the coop. Just enough that the young rooster's eyes widened a little more, and the oldest hen, who had seen many strange things in her long chicken life, leaned forward.

"A long time ago," Story said, "before there was time, there was no day. There was only night. The sun did not yet rise. It lay deep in the dark water beneath the world, dim and asleep, and the world above was cold.

"The plants did not grow. The fishermen could not see their nets. The people shivered through the long, long dark.

"And the silver fish, who lived in the deep water, noticed.

"The silver fish were small. No longer than a finger. But there were a great many of them. And one of them — the first one — said: *We could lift it.*

"The others said: *It's too heavy. It's too far down. We are too small.*

"The first one said: *For one of us, yes. For all of us, maybe not.*

"And so they went. All of them, together, deep down into the cold dark, until they found the sun lying on the bottom of the world. And they each took hold of a tiny piece of it. The corners. The edges. The little ridges of warmth along its rim. Every fish bit gently down on its own small piece.

"And they began to swim upward.

"It was very hard. The sun was heavier than they had thought. The water was darker than they had thought. They swam, and swam, and got tired, and some of them wanted to let go. But the others said:

keep going. We're almost there. And the truth is, they were not almost there. They had a long way still to go. But saying it helped.

"And then — just before the very end of the long dark — the silver fish broke the surface. And the sun rose, dripping water, into the sky. And the world above turned gold for the first time. The first dawn."

The young rooster was very still.

"But the fish were tired," Story said. "Some of them slipped back into the cold water. The sun, lifted, slowly fell again. Night came back.

"And so the next morning, the silver fish came again. They had to. Without them, there would be no dawn.

"And they have come every morning since. Every fish a little piece. No fish doing it alone. No fish able to skip a day, because the sun would not rise. But also — and this is the important part, little one — *no fish having to hold up the whole sun*. No fish has ever had to do that. Not even the first one. Not even the bravest. Not even the one who started it all.

"When the fisherman told this story to his son, he said: *Every job worth doing is held up by many. You hold your piece. You don't have to hold the whole sun. You couldn't, even if you tried. But if you don't hold your piece, the world is a little dimmer*."

She paused.

"Out there right now," she said, "as we are talking, the silver fish are working. They are deep under the world, and they are pulling. And in a little while, the sun will rise.

"But it isn't only them. There is a milkmaid in a village three farms over who has just lit a lamp. There is a baker who has been kneading dough since two hours ago. There is a fisherman somewhere — perhaps the same one who told this story — pushing his boat out onto cold water with cold hands. There is an old woman, in a stone hut very far away, who has just put a kettle on a fire.

"And there is a young rooster in a coop, who is about to crow.

"You are part of it, little one. You always have been. You are not the only thing holding up the sun. Nobody is. But if you don't sing, the morning is a little quieter. So sing. Not because the sun depends on it. Because *you are part of the morning*. The same way the fish are. The same way the milkmaid is. The same way your father was."

The young rooster's eyes had filled with tears.

"It will come up?" he whispered. "Even if I'm late? Even if I'm quiet?"

"It will come up. The fish are pulling. The bakers are baking. The old women are boiling water. You are part of a *very* large team."

"Was father part of it too?"

"Your father was a wonderful piece of it. He held his part for many, many mornings. And now you hold yours."

The young rooster wiped his face with his wing.

He stood up.

He climbed onto the wooden roost. He shook out his uneven tail feathers. He tilted back his head.

And he crowed.

It was not a perfect crow. It cracked in the middle. It was a little too high. It was, frankly, the kind of crow you laugh at when you are not the rooster making it.

But it was his.

And in the long second after, while the young rooster stood with his head still tilted back and his eyes screwed shut, waiting for the world to end —

The first sliver of gold appeared on the horizon.

The sun came up.

Just like the silver fish had promised. Just like every other morning. Just on time.

The hens, all of them, made small approving sounds. The oldest one nodded slowly to herself.

The young rooster opened one eye, then the other. He looked east. He looked at his hens. He looked at Story.

"It came up."

"It did."

"I — I helped?"

"You held your piece."

The young rooster sat down very suddenly on the roost, as if his legs had stopped working all at once.

"Oh," he said.

That was all he said. But Story knew that *oh*. It was the same *oh* her mother had made, on the night she had hatched. The *oh* of a thing being understood.

Story flew on as the morning grew.

The sun was up properly now, climbing the sky the way the sun does, as if it had never been heavy at all. Below her, the country was waking. Smoke from kitchens. A dog barking somewhere. A truck on a far-off road. A man walking out into a field with a bucket.

She thought about what she had just said.

You are part of it. You always have been.

She had said it to the rooster. But somewhere along the way — somewhere in the middle of the silver fish swimming up through cold dark water — she had realized she had been saying it to herself, too.

She was a Story Owl. She was not the only thing keeping the stories alive. She wasn't even the most important. There were grandmothers in stone huts and old men by campfires and herons in marshes and fishermen by great rivers, and they were all carrying their pieces. She was carrying hers.

She didn't have to hold up the whole sun.

She just had to keep flying.

She turned north and angled into the wind, and the two small silver crescents at her wingtips flashed once, twice, in the new morning light, and she went home.

End of Chapter Six.

Chapter Seven: The Promise

She had not forgotten.

For all the months she had been south — the desert, the great river, the jungle, the high mountains, the long flight home — there had been something tucked away in the back of her mind. A small bright thing she had not allowed herself to lose. A barn, two miles east of an old half-collapsed shed. A small swallow in the rafters, half-asleep in warm hay-scented dark. *I'll see you in the spring.*

Spring was here.

She had come up out of the south slowly, riding the warm air, watching the world below her change from brown to green as she went. The fields had begun to plow themselves. The willows by the rivers had turned that first hopeful yellow they turn before the leaves come.

And the swallows had come back.

She knew this because she had been watching. For two days she had seen them — small, dark, sharp-winged, swooping over fields and fence-lines, in pairs and in loose flocks. Coming up from the south, the way she was. Beating her, even, on some stretches of wind. She could not match a swallow for speed. Nobody could.

She had wondered, every time a flock had passed her, whether the small one was among them.

She did not know the answer. So she had to go and see.

The barn was easy to find. It was the kind of place a Story Owl remembers without trying.

The shed had collapsed the rest of the way over the winter — its roof was on the ground now, with grass already growing through it. The barn, though, was the same. Red. Tin-roofed. Rows of glassless windows. The wide upper door propped open for swallows.

She landed in a dead elm at the edge of the farmyard and waited.

She did not want to barge in. If the swallow had not made it, she did not want to find out by frightening anyone. And if the swallow *had* made it — well. Story did not know what to do with that, either. So she waited.

The afternoon was warm. The sun was thick and gold. The barn door was busy. Swallows swooped in and out in long slanting curves, fast as thoughts.

And then a familiar voice, very close to her ear, said: "I knew you'd come."

Story turned her head.

A swallow was sitting on a branch a wing-length from hers. Small for a swallow, even now — a little fuller, a little glossier, but still small, still unmistakable.

"You're alive," Story breathed.

"I am."

"Your family — "

"They came back six days ago. I was watching for them. I saw them coming. My mother nearly fell out of the air when she realized.

She thought she had lost me."

Story did not know what to say.

The swallow's eyes were bright. She was holding very still, the way a swallow almost never does.

"I waited a long time for you," she said. "I told the chickens about you. They didn't really believe me. But the old hen — the white-faced one — she said: *if she said she'd come back, she'll come back. Owls don't make promises lightly.* So I kept watching the sky."

"I've been very far."

"I can see."

The swallow looked at the silver crescents on Story's wingtips, and at the other marks. She blinked slowly, as if reading.

"More marks."

"Yes."

"Are you finished?"

"Finished?"

"With travelling. With gathering."

Story thought about it. "No. I don't think a Story Owl is ever finished. But I'm coming home. For now."

"Home."

The swallow said the word as if it were itself a small story.

"Story," she said. "Before we go and meet my family. I want to tell you something."

"All right."

The swallow looked up. Her small dark eyes were very serious.

"I have a story now."

"A story?"

"My own. I made it up over the winter. I haven't told anyone yet. Not even my mother. I wanted to tell you first."

Story's heart did a small unexpected thing. "Tell me."

The swallow took a breath.

"There was a bird who got left behind. — That's me. I'm not pretending it's somebody else.

"So I had to live in a barn over a whole winter. And I was cold and I was sad and I missed everybody. And one day, in the middle of December, when the wind was very bad, I figured something out.

"I figured out that waiting is not the opposite of flying.

"Waiting is what flying *is*, the rest of the time. A swallow flies for a few weeks twice a year. That's it. The rest of the year, we sit on wires. We rest. We eat. We *wait*. The flying is the small part. The waiting is the big part.

"I'd never thought about it before. I'd always thought flying was the point, and waiting was the in-between. But actually waiting is *most of it*. And once I understood that, the winter wasn't waiting *for* something. The winter was just being a swallow. The way flying south is what I do in autumn. Wintering in a barn was what I did in winter.

"It got easier after that. Not easy. But easier."

She paused.

"That's the whole story. I made it up myself. It isn't very long."

"It's a beautiful story," Story said, and she meant it.

"Really?"

"Really."

"Will you carry it?"

Story understood at once. The swallow had not asked her to like the story, or to repeat it, or to remember it. She had asked her to *carry* it. To make it one of the things she travelled with. To put it on her body alongside the great big myths from the great big places.

"Yes," Story said. "I would be honored to."

She felt the warmth come almost at once. Quiet. Quick. In the centre of her chest, just below the two flames, where there had been only smooth feather. A small heat gathered. Then it stilled.

She looked down.

Two small dark dots. One on the left, one on the right. Mirrored. Tiny. Hardly anything. Like the dots above a question mark. Or the period at the end of a sentence. Or two eyes, almost closed.

A pause.

A still place.

The mark of a story about waiting.

The swallow saw the marks and her own eyes filled. "Mine?"

"Yours."

"Oh."

That was all she said. But Story knew that *oh*. She had heard it before.

Inside the barn it was warm with the smell of straw, and loud with swallow chatter. Story did not go all the way in — she sat in the open frame of the upper door, where the daylight ended and the soft barn-dimness began. Even there, the swallows nearly came apart with excitement.

"This is her," the small swallow announced. "This is the owl. Mother. *Mother.* This is her."

A larger swallow flew down from a rafter and landed on the lintel an arm's length from Story. Her eyes were bright. Her wings were trembling.

"You," she said. "You're the one."

"Yes."

"You stayed with my daughter."

"For a little while. I had somewhere to put her — "

"You *saved* my daughter."

Story did not know what to say to that.

The mother swallow stepped closer. Her voice was very quiet now.

"I lost her," she said. "I didn't know the moment it happened, but I knew it before we got to the south. I had to keep flying. The others had to keep flying. We had to leave her. And every day, all winter long, I woke up in that warm country and I knew it. And I thought —

I thought I would never — "

She stopped. She blinked hard.

"And then we came back. And there she was. *In the rafter we always nest on.* Sitting there. Looking up. Waiting."

The mother swallow looked at Story for a long moment.

"I'm not going to ask how. Or why. Or anything. I just want you to know. I am thanking you in the only way I can."

She bowed her small dark head once, slowly. Then she turned, and flew back up to her rafter, and disappeared into the busy barn-light.

The small swallow looked at Story.

"I told her about you. She wanted to know everything. I told her you came down out of the rafters when I asked you not to eat me. And how you told me a story about a river of stars. And how you came back. And how you found me a place. I think she's been wanting to meet you for months."

"It looks that way."

The small swallow smiled. Then, after a moment: "I'll never see you again, will I?"

Story had been about to say *of course you will*. But she stopped. Because she didn't know if it was true.

"I don't know," she said honestly. "I'm a Story Owl. I don't know where I'll go."

"That's all right," the small swallow said. "I'll carry the story you gave me. And you'll carry the story I gave you. And we'll be in each

other anyway."

Story flew.

The afternoon turned to evening. The fields turned from green to gold. Far ahead of her, where the sun was beginning to go down, was a long dark line on the horizon — the forest she had first opened her wings over. The deep dark forest where she had been born.

She was almost home.

She thought about her mother. About her father. About Oak and Ash, who would not be in the nest anymore — they would have their own territories now, in their own corners of the woods. About the branch she had hatched on. About her father's *huh*. About her mother's voice in the dark. About all the stories she now carried.

The flames. The feathers. The waves. The stars. The fish. The vines. The silver crescents at her wingtips.

And now, tucked just below the flames, two small dark dots that nobody but her and one small swallow in a barn would ever understand.

Waiting is what flying is the rest of the time, she thought.

It was the simplest thing anyone had told her in a year.

She angled into the last warm wind of the day, and her wing-tips flashed silver, and she went on.

End of Chapter Seven.

Chapter Eight: The Old Tree

She came over the forest at dusk.

She had flown for two more nights since the barn, sleeping in scraps of woods and on the corners of unfamiliar barns, feeling the country grow less and less strange under her wings. The land had pulled her north all the way up out of warm fields into colder green ones, and then into the country of the great old trees. Pines first. Then spruces. Then cedars. Then the deep-shouldered firs of her own forest.

She knew the moment she crossed the line. The wind smelled of resin. The light fell differently between the trunks. Birds she had not heard in a year called from somewhere far below.

She was almost too afraid to land.

She had not realized, until she was nearly there, how afraid she was. What if Cedar had been taken by something. What if Willow had aged badly. What if Oak and Ash had fallen out with the family. What if the tree itself had come down in a winter storm. What if she came back and there was nothing.

She slowed.

She flew along a ridge for a long time, looking down. She circled a meadow she half-recognized. She almost landed on the wrong tree once — a tree that looked like the right tree but wasn't.

And then, finally, the right tree.

It was the same. The crown was a little fuller. The branch she had hatched on had a small new growth of needles around it. But the

great curved limb where the nest sat — that was the same. Exactly the same. As if she had been gone for an evening, not a year.

She circled it once.

And from the nest, she heard her mother's voice.

"Story?"

Story did not answer. She could not.

She landed in the nest. Half-fell into it, really; her wings gave out the last few feet. She came down on the soft mossy bottom, and Willow was there — older, definitely older, a streak of grey at her ear-tufts that had not been there before — and Willow was crying, quietly, the way owls cry, which is mostly with the eyes. She did not say *where have you been*. She did not say *we worried*. She said only:

"Oh, my heart. Oh."

She gathered Story in. Story was bigger now than her mother. They both noticed. Neither said it. Willow tucked her head under Story's wing, and the two of them sat there on the moss, and the daylight slowly drained out of the sky.

After a while there was a heavy thump on the branch above.

Cedar.

He had a vole in his talons, the way he always did, the way he always would. He looked at his daughter for a long time without speaking.

Then he set the vole down very carefully.

"You're taller than your mother," he said.

"Hello, Father."

He came and stood beside them, and pressed his shoulder gently against Story's. He did not say *hello*. He did not say *I'm glad you're back*. He did not say any of the things a less Cedar-ish owl might have said.

He said: "Huh."

But it was a different *huh* than she had ever heard from him before.

Story stayed in the nest a long time without saying anything. She did not know where to begin.

Willow saved her the trouble.

"Don't try to tell us all of it. Not tonight. You'll be telling us for the rest of your life. Just tell us — were you all right? Did you eat? Did you find somewhere safe to sleep most nights?"

"Most nights."

"Did you make friends?"

"A few."

"Did you tell any?"

Story knew what she meant.

"Two."

"Two!" Willow's eyes went very bright. "Cedar. Two."

"I heard you, woman."

"Two stories told. Two of her own."

"I *heard* you."

Cedar pretended to fuss with the vole. Then, very briefly, he leaned over and pressed his beak gently against the top of Story's head.

"Well done," he said quietly. "That's well done."

She tucked her head under his chin and stayed very still for a long time.

She asked, after a while, about her brothers. Cedar told her. Oak had taken a territory two valleys east, on a cliff above a creek. He had a mate now, a barred owl from the lowlands. There were eggs. Ash had gone north — he was up in the country of the lakes, where the trees got smaller. He hadn't taken a mate yet, but he was hunting like a champion, and Cedar suspected he was simply being picky.

"They'll come and see you," Cedar said. "Once they hear. Give it a week."

"All right."

"They'll be insufferable. Oak will pretend he wasn't worried. Ash will pretend he was *more* worried than I was, which won't be true."

Story laughed for the first time since landing.

The night came down properly. The forest filled with the small sounds she had grown up listening to — the rustle, the distant call, the river under everything. It was as if she had never left.

Eventually Willow stirred.

"Story. I have one for you."

"One?"

"A story. I've been saving it."

"You have?"

"Since you left. I knew you would come back with so many. I wanted to have one ready. Something you wouldn't have heard out there."

"Where did you hear it?"

"From your grandmother. Cedar's mother. The same one who told him about the Story Owl, the night you were born."

Cedar made a small sound. "She told you *that* one too?"

"She told me a lot of things, Cedar. She liked me."

"She did," he admitted.

Willow settled. She looked at Story. Her eyes were very steady now — no more tears, just the deep careful focus that meant she was about to do the thing she did better than anything in the world.

"It's a story," she said, "about how humans got their legs."

Story felt something quicken in her chest, the way it always did when a story was about to begin.

"Tell me," she said.

"A long time ago," Willow began, "humans were not the way they are now.

"They had four legs.

"They ran the way the deer run, and the foxes, and the wolves, and almost everything else that walks on land. Four legs is a very good way to be. You're stable. You're fast. Nothing knocks you over. The ground is always close. You can drink without bending, and you can run from danger without thinking. Most of the world chose four legs, and most of the world has been very happy with the choice.

"Humans were like that, in the beginning. Four-legged creatures, quick and strong. They ran in packs. They hunted. They drank from rivers without lowering their heads. Their world was a low, fast world.

"And they were lonely.

"They didn't know they were lonely. They were just — humans. They didn't have a comparison. But there was a feeling they kept having and could not name. They would see one of their pack from across a meadow, and they would feel a *pulling* — they would *want something*. And they didn't know what they wanted. So they ran. They ran together, in their packs, faster than anything could catch them. But the wanting did not go away.

"One day, an old human stopped.

"She was a grandmother of her pack. She had run her whole life. And she was tired. She lay down on the grass at the edge of a clearing, and she did not get up.

"Her pack stopped. They came back. They stood around her — on their four legs — and they looked down at her, and she looked up at them.

"And she said — and this was the first time any human had said anything quite like this —

"*I have always wanted to hold you.*

"They didn't understand. *Hold us how?*

"*With my front paws. Around your shoulders. The way the wind holds the trees.*

"And they tried. But they couldn't. Not on four legs. Their front paws were for running. Their shoulders were for running. There was no way to wrap one human around another. They could press their faces together. They could lean. But they could not *hold*.

"And the grandmother, who had wanted this her whole life and never known the word for it, closed her eyes and died.

"Her pack stayed with her for three days. They did not eat. They did not run. They stood around her on four legs, and they tried to feel what she had felt, and they could not.

"And then — and the old grandmothers say it was the wind, but I am not sure — something spoke. Maybe the world. Maybe just the part of the world that watches small things like humans and worries about them. Whatever it was, it said:

"*I can change you. But it will cost.*

"The pack listened.

"*If you wish, I can take two of your legs. I will turn them into something else. The front pair. The pair that used to be for running. They will become — different. Longer. With many small parts at the end. They will not be paws anymore. They will not even be legs anymore. They will be something the world has not had before. And with them, you will be able to hold each other. You will be able to wrap one of you around another. You will be able to lift small ones,*

and carry water, and weave, and plant, and make music with the very tips of you.

"*But.*

"*You will be slow. You will fall down often, especially at first. The wolves will catch you. The deer will outrun you. You will walk on two legs for the rest of time, and your two legs will be unsteady, and you will have to balance with your whole body, every step, forever. You will lose much of what you were.*

"*Do you want this?*

"And the pack thought.

"Some of them said no. They said: *we are good as we are. Speed is everything. We will not give it up.* And those humans walked away on four legs, and they kept walking, and they have never stopped. The old grandmothers say that some of them, in the end, became the other four-legged things. Wolves. Foxes. Bears. The fast quiet ones. They are our cousins, and they remember.

"But most of the humans said yes.

"They said: *take them. Take our front legs. We want to hold each other more than we want to run.*

"And the world took the front legs. And it made them into something new. Long. With elbows. With wrists. With five small parts at the end of each one. The humans stood up — wobbling, falling, getting back up — and they balanced on their two remaining legs, and they used their new front-things to push themselves off the ground when they fell, which was often.

"And then, as soon as they could stand still, they did the thing they had been waiting their whole lives to do.

"They put their new long parts around each other.

"And they held."

Willow was quiet a moment.

"That is why they are slow. That is why they fall down. That is why a human child, when it is new, takes a year before it can walk. That is why a human is the easiest creature in the forest to kill, if you are something that wants to kill it.

"And that is also why every house in the world has a door wide enough for two people walking close. That is why every human song has someone clapping. That is why every human carries something. That is why the humans you have seen — the grandfather at the campfire, the small girl, the fisherman, the boy in the stone hut, the swallow's farm-wife — they all have arms. The arms used to be legs. They are the legs they gave up *so they could hold each other*. Every one of them, walking around with two legs and two arms, is walking around with the choice their oldest grandmother made, on the grass beside her dying friend.

"Every embrace in the world. Every baby lifted. Every old man's hand held by his daughter. Every loaf of bread carried home. Every fire kept alive by a person crouched over it.

"All of it. Came from the legs they let go of."

She stopped.

The forest was very still.

Story, after a long time, said: "Mother. That is the most beautiful story I have ever heard."

"I know," Willow said quietly. "That's why I saved it for you."

The warmth came almost at once, in a place she had not had a mark before. On her belly, between the curling green vines from the jungle child's story, two small dark figures appeared. Standing upright. Arms outstretched. One on each side, mirrored.

Tiny humans. Walking on two legs. Their arms held nothing yet, because the mark had nobody for them to hold. But standing.

She looked down at them and felt her eyes fill.

"Oh," she said.

Cedar leaned over and looked. He squinted.

"They look like little people."

"They are."

"Huh."

But it was the *huh* he had said when she had come home. Not the *huh* of his old reluctance. The *huh* of being moved and not having the words for it.

That night she slept between her parents, the way she had as a small owlet. Willow's wing on one side. Cedar's shoulder against her back. She had thought she would lie awake for hours, listening to the forest she had missed, taking it all back in.

But she fell asleep almost at once.

The last thing she remembered, before sleep, was thinking about the old grandmother human in the story. Lying on the grass. Saying *I have always wanted to hold you.* And about how the world had listened. And about how, when you are very tired, somewhere far above your tree, sometimes the wind hears.

She slept until the sun was high.

When she woke, the nest was warm. Willow was hunting. Cedar was asleep on the branch above, snoring the way he always had. Story stretched her wings — slowly, carefully — and looked down at her own body.

Flames. Feathers. Waves. Stars. Fish. Vines. Silver crescents. Two small dots beneath the flames. Two small standing figures on her belly.

She thought: I should go and find Oak. I should find Ash. They will not believe any of this.

But not today.

Today she was home.

She tucked her head back under her wing, and she closed her eyes, and she let herself, for one whole day, simply be a daughter in her mother's nest. With nowhere to go. With no story she had to gather. With no one to tell anything to.

The forest stayed quiet around her.

The world, for once, could hold up the sun without her.

End of Chapter Eight.

Chapter Nine: The Mirror

The summer turned to autumn, and Story did not leave.

She had thought she would. She had thought, when she landed home, that she would rest a few days and then fly again. But the days had become weeks, and the weeks had become months, and the leaves had begun to turn on the great firs, and still she was at home in the nest, between her parents, like a much younger owl than she really was.

It was not that home was bad. Home was wonderful. Willow was warm. Cedar was quiet. The forest was full of small comforts — the river under everything, the foxes in the roots, the moss that grew thick on the branches.

But something was wrong.

She felt it most at dusk, when she should have been most alive. The hour the rest of the forest woke up, she felt herself becoming sleepier. Her wings went stiff. Her ears went quiet. The pull she used to feel — toward stories, toward the next horizon — was muffled.

Once, she caught herself thinking: *I could just stay.*

She didn't say so. But she caught herself thinking it.

The marks on her body felt heavy in a way they hadn't before. As if she were tired of carrying them. As if a Story Owl who didn't fly was just a strange-looking owl with too many spots.

She didn't know what to do.

One evening Cedar caught her at it.

She was sitting on the branch above the nest, looking south. Just looking.

Cedar landed beside her without a sound.

"You're doing it again."

"Doing what?"

"Looking. The way you do."

"I was just — "

"You've been just for two months."

Story did not answer. Cedar settled himself on the branch and tucked his wings.

"Daughter. I don't tell you what to do. I never have. I'm not going to start now. But I know what I'm watching. You have a thing in you that wants to be somewhere else. And the longer you don't follow it, the more it will weigh you down."

"I don't know where to go."

"You don't have to know where. You just have to start."

"Father. It's not that simple. I've gathered a lot. I've told a few. I'm — I'm something now, I think. But I don't know what *kind* of something. I don't know what I'm *for*."

Cedar was quiet for a long while.

"You should go and see your grandmother," he said finally.

Story turned her head. "Your mother?"

"My mother. She's still alive. She lives a day and a half east of here, in a tall old fir on the edge of a creek. She's older than anyone has any right to be. Her eyes don't work very well, and her wings barely take her between branches. But her ears still work. So does the rest of her."

"Father. You haven't seen her in — "

"That is between her and me, and I don't want to talk about it. But she has been waiting for you. She told your mother and me, the night you hatched, that one day you would come and find her. She's been waiting twelve years. I think you should go now."

Story stared at him.

"Tonight?"

"Tonight. Yes. Why not."

He almost smiled.

"Take it from a father. The thing you don't want to do is the thing you should do first."

She flew east. The directions were good. A day and a half, a creek, a tall old fir. She found it just before dawn on the second day.

The tree was enormous. Even older than the tree she had been hatched in. Its bark was deeply ridged. Its branches were sparse at the top — many had broken off in storms. Halfway up, on the eastern side, was a hollow.

Story landed on a branch beside the hollow.

"Grandmother?"

A voice came from inside. A voice like dry leaves rubbed together. Quiet. Steady.

"You're late."

Story did not know what to say. "I — "

"Twelve years late. But come in. Come in, granddaughter. Let me hear you."

Story stepped into the hollow.

It was warm. It smelled of moss and feather. It was barely wide enough for two adult Great Horned Owls.

Her grandmother was sitting at the back of the hollow, very still. She was small — much smaller than Cedar. Smaller than Willow. Smaller, even, than Story was now. Her feathers were grey-white, fine as hoarfrost. Her face was deeply lined. Her great yellow eyes were clouded — a soft milky white had grown over them, so that she looked at the world as if through fog.

She was nearly blind.

"Come closer. Let me feel your face."

Story stepped close. Her grandmother lifted one frail wing and pressed it gently against Story's cheek.

"Oh," she breathed. "Oh, you have a great deal of him in you. And of her. And of yourself. Stand still, child. Let me see what you carry."

Story stood still.

The old owl let her wing brush along Story's body — the flames on the chest, the dots beneath them, the figures on the belly, the

vines, the fish, the feathers on the shoulders, the waves along the wing, the stars on the crown, the silver on the wingtips. She did not say anything for a long time.

Finally she said: "Nine."

"Nine, Grandmother?"

"Nine stories. You have gathered nine. I have not seen so many on one young owl since — " she stopped. "Well. Since a long time ago."

"There were others?"

"There have been others. Long before you. Long before me. There will be others after. Sit, granddaughter. Sit. We have one night and one day before you have to fly back. I have a story for you that I have wanted to tell someone for sixty years."

"It's a story from very far away. From a country full of small islands and white stones, on the eastern side of a sea you have never crossed. From a long time ago, when the gods of that country still walked among the people. The people there had many stories about gods, but this is one of the harder ones. I'll tell it the way it was told to me."

Story settled. The hollow seemed to grow quieter around them.

"There was once a young man named Perseus. He grew up on a small island, with only his mother. He did not know his father. The truth was that his father was a god — Zeus, the king of the gods — but Perseus did not know that, and his mother had never told him.

"On the island where they lived, there was a king. The king wanted to marry Perseus's mother. She did not want to marry him.

The king was a cruel man, and he decided that the only way to have her was to get rid of her son.

"So one day, in front of a great gathering of guests, the king said to Perseus: *I want a wedding gift from each of you. From you, young man, I want the head of Medusa.*

"Now everyone who heard this gasped. Because Medusa was not a person to ask for the head of."

"Why?" Story asked.

"Because Medusa was a monster. At least, she had become a monster. She had not always been one.

"A long time before Perseus was born, Medusa had been a beautiful young woman. A priestess. She served Athena, the goddess of wisdom, in Athena's great temple. She was kind and clever and good.

"And then something terrible happened to her. She was hurt — *badly* hurt — by another god, in Athena's own temple. And Athena, who could not punish the other god because gods cannot punish each other, punished *Medusa* instead. Athena turned her into a creature with snakes for hair, whose face was so terrible that anyone who looked at her turned to stone. And Athena sent her to live at the edge of the world, with her two sisters, where no one would have to see her.

"Medusa had not done anything wrong. The world had been cruel to her, and then it had punished her for being hurt. It happens, granddaughter. Not often. But sometimes. The world is not always fair.

"So when the king said *bring me Medusa's head*, what he meant was *die in the trying*. Because nobody who had ever gone to find Medusa had come back. They had all looked at her, and they had all become stone.

"Perseus said yes. He had no choice. The king had cornered him.

"He went home and he wept. He told his mother he was going to fail. He had no weapons. He had no ship. He didn't even know where the edge of the world was.

"And his mother said: *go up the mountain. Pray. The gods know who your father is.*

"So Perseus went up the mountain. And on the mountain he was met by Athena. Yes — the same Athena. The one who had cursed Medusa. Over the long years, Athena had come to regret what she had done. She could not undo it. She could not bring Medusa back to herself. But she could help a young man do what she could not bring herself to do — release Medusa from her own curse, by ending it.

"Athena gave him a polished bronze shield. *Use this,* she said. *It is a mirror. Do not look at her. Look at her in the shield.*

"Hermes, the messenger god, gave him winged sandals. *To fly,* he said. *The way you'll need to.*

"Hades, the god of the underworld, gave him a helmet that made him invisible. *So she will not see you coming.*

"And someone, somewhere along the way, gave him a sword. A good one. Sharp. Forged for one job.

"Perseus took these gifts. He flew to the edge of the world. He found the cave. He went in invisible. He held the shield in front of

him. He did not look at Medusa directly. He looked at her reflection. And — while she slept, while her snakes hissed gently in their dreams — he raised his sword, and he ended it."

The grandmother paused.

"And from her neck, in the moment she died, something rose up.

"Pegasus.

"A great white winged horse. Beautiful beyond anything else in any story. He flew up out of her ending and into the sky, and he has been flying ever since. He was Medusa's child. Born from the worst moment in any story she had ever been in. The world had taken everything from her — her beauty, her work, her name. And in the very last instant, she gave the world Pegasus. The most beautiful thing the world has."

The grandmother was quiet a long time.

"Perseus took her head home in a bag, and he did the things he had to do. He saved a princess from a sea monster, by turning the monster to stone. He came home and made the cruel king face the same mirror he had used. And then, when his work was done, he gave the head to Athena. She put it on her shield, where Medusa could finally rest. Athena carried that shield for the rest of her time. Some say she carried it because it was strong. I think she carried it because she had not forgotten what she had done."

"Granddaughter."

"Yes, Grandmother."

"Why do you think I have wanted to tell you that story, of all the stories I know, on the night you came to see me?"

Story did not answer. She knew this was the kind of question that did not want an answer right away.

"There are four things in that story I want you to take home with you. Just four. Listen carefully.

"The first thing. Perseus could not do it alone. *Every* gift he carried came from somebody else. The shield. The sandals. The helmet. The sword. The directions. *Every one.* When he went to face the worst thing in the world, he did not face it alone. He faced it carrying a kit assembled from many hands.

"You think you go alone, granddaughter. You don't. Every story you carry is a gift somebody gave you. The flames are Athena's shield. The feathers are Hermes's sandals. The waves and the stars and the silver and the dots and the figures — they are your kit. You did not assemble them. The world assembled them on you. When you go out again — and you *will* go out again, child, you cannot stay where you are, your father knows it and so do you — you will not be going alone. You have never been alone."

She paused.

"The second thing. Perseus did not look at Medusa directly. He used the shield. *That is what stories are.* Stories are how we look at terrible things sideways. The world has things in it that, looked at directly, will turn you to stone. They will. I have seen it happen. People have looked too hard at something terrible and gone — quiet. Stiff. Unable to move. Stone people, walking around. *Don't be a stone person.* When you meet a terrible thing — and you will,

because you fly — look at it through a story. Carry it home in a story. Show it to others in a story. That is what your work is. That is what a Story Owl *does*. You are a polished shield. You are the way the world looks at the worst of itself without going to stone."

Story's eyes were very wide.

"The third thing. Medusa was not a monster. Medusa was a girl who was hurt, and then punished for being hurt. The shape of her at the end — the snakes, the gaze — was not who she was. It was what had been done to her.

"Granddaughter. You are going to meet many things on your travels that look like monsters. Most of them — *most* — will be Medusas. People who were hurt, and got worse from it. Animals who were lost, and went strange. Whole towns that have been forgotten by the world, and have curdled. You will be tempted to think they are evil. They are not. They are hurt. The work of an *adult* — not a child, an adult — is to know the difference. To bring Athena's regret instead of Athena's anger.

"And the fourth thing. The fourth is the strangest, and the most important.

"From Medusa's terrible end came Pegasus.

"From the worst night in any story came the most beautiful thing in any story. A flying horse, white as snow, free as wind, who has flown above the world ever since.

"The world makes Pegasus, granddaughter. Out of the hard parts. Not out of the easy ones. Out of the ones we do not want to look at. *Don't be afraid of the hard parts.* From the hard parts come the wings."

She stopped.

The hollow was completely silent.

"That," she said, "is the story I wanted to give you."

Story was crying. She had not meant to. She didn't notice it had started. Her grandmother reached out one fragile wing and gently touched her face.

"There," she said softly. "There. It's all right. It happens with that one."

The warmth came.

Not in her chest. Not on her belly. Somewhere new — behind her eyes, on the soft feathered place between her eye and her ear-tuft, on each side. A small heat, gathering and stilling.

Story turned and looked at her own reflection in a small still pool of rainwater that had gathered in a knot of the hollow wall.

Two small, perfect ovals. One behind each eye. Polished, almost glossy. Like little bronze shields. Mirrors angled outward, from her own face into the world.

"That's good placement," her grandmother said, who could barely see. "Athena would approve."

"How did you know — "

"I can hear when a mark comes. They make a tiny sound. Like a feather landing. I have been listening for that sound for a long time."

She drew her wing back.

"Stay until tomorrow night. Sleep here. Eat what I have, which isn't much. Tell me one of yours. You owe me. You're nine ahead."

Story stayed. She slept under her grandmother's shoulder, the way she had slept under Willow's wing. She told her the story of the small swallow in the barn — the one the swallow had made up, about how waiting was what flying was the rest of the time. Her grandmother listened with her clouded eyes closed, and when it was done, she said: "She made that up *herself*? That little swallow? Granddaughter. Find her again someday. Tell her I heard it. Tell her an old owl on the other side of the country listened to her story and was made better by it."

The next evening Story flew home.

She came in low over the forest and landed on the nest at full dark. Willow was there. Cedar was on the branch above. They looked at her — at her face, at the new small bronze ovals behind her eyes — and they understood. Both of them. Without anything being said.

"You're going again," Willow said.

"Yes."

"When?"

"Soon."

"Where?"

"I don't know yet."

Cedar grunted. "You don't have to know where. You just have to start."

Story laughed — wet, a little — and pressed her face into her father's shoulder.

"That's what your father said," she told Willow.

"Then he was right for once," Willow said.

Cedar made his *huh*. But it was a *huh* of being teased, this time, by his wife. Not the *huh* of being moved. Story had heard them all now. She was beginning to know which was which.

She thought, as she fell asleep that night between her parents:

I am not alone. I never have been. Every mark on me is a gift. Stories are the way I look at the worst of the world without breaking. The monsters I will meet are mostly hurt creatures. And the hardest things I face will give me Pegasus.

She thought: *That is what kind of owl I am. That is what I am for.*

In the morning she would talk with her father about where Oak and Ash were. She wanted to see her brothers before she left. After that — she didn't know after that. But she knew she would go.

The forest stayed very quiet around her. And somewhere a day and a half east, in a hollow in a great old fir, an old, old owl listened to the night for the small sound of marks coming, and was satisfied.

End of Chapter Nine.

Chapter Ten: Two Hills

Story flew for many weeks.

She had said goodbye to her brothers in the late autumn. Oak in his territory east of home, with his mate and three new owlets, all of them bigger than they should have been. Ash up in the lake country, alone but no longer picky, just settled into a particular kind of quiet northern living that suited him. They had both pretended not to be impressed by her marks. Both of them had, eventually, asked her one question or another, and looked at the marks longer than they had meant to. She had laughed at them. They had hooted at her. It had been the kind of farewell she had always wanted.

Then she had gone west. Further than she had ever gone before.

She had crossed a wide flat country of grass that ran for days. She had crossed a great mountain range white at the top, and a desert of pale stone, and another mountain range, and a lake so wide she could not see the other side. She had gathered three more stories along the way — small ones, mostly, told by hawks and old shepherds and a young girl in a tent — and the marks for them had appeared in their proper places, quiet and quick, like a hand reaching out to add a bead to a string.

She did not count anymore. She had stopped counting after the night with her grandmother. *You are your kit,* the old owl had said. *Every mark on you is a gift.* It was a thing she repeated, sometimes, on long flights when the wind was pushing against her. It helped.

She was over a country of long green hills now. The hills were terraced with rice fields, and the fields were full of water and shining

like mirrors in the late afternoon light. Roofs with curved corners rose between them. Streams ran down toward unseen rivers.

She had been flying since before dawn.

She was very tired.

She did not see the goshawk at first.

He must have been watching her for a long time. He must have seen her come slow over the second-to-last ridge, must have seen her wing-tip droop, must have judged exactly when to dive. By the time she heard the shape of him in the air behind her, he was already too close.

She rolled.

She had learned, on her travels, how to roll. The heron in the marsh had taught her, years ago, that a Story Owl was made for distance, not for fighting. *You don't have to fly like your brothers*, he had said. *You'll fly farther. But not faster.* She had never had cause to fight in the air. She had learned, instead, to dodge.

She rolled, and the goshawk's talons missed her by less than a wing-length, and the wind of his pass nearly knocked her sideways out of the sky.

He banked. He was a beautiful, terrible bird — rust-and-grey, broad-chested, eyes the color of fire. He did not call out. Goshawks don't. They come in silent.

He climbed, and turned, and dove again.

Story did the only thing she could think of. She folded her wings and dropped.

She fell three hundred feet down the side of a green hill, terrace by terrace, past startled water-buffalo and hopping frogs and a fisherman who looked up and shouted something she could not understand. She pulled out at the last second, low and ragged, and skimmed across the surface of a flooded paddy, her wing-tips kicking up small white sprays.

She did not look back.

Ahead of her, on the side of the next hill, was a stand of old trees. Cypress, perhaps, and one great gnarled fig, and a low wall of pale stone surrounding a small temple.

She made for the trees.

She got there. Just. The goshawk's second strike caught the trailing edge of her wing — a hot ripping pain, a few feathers torn loose, a thin line of blood across her secondary flight feathers — but she was inside the canopy of the great fig before he could turn for a third pass.

She climbed deep into the foliage. The fig was enormous — its leaves were thick as plates, dark green, layered like roof-tiles — and she pushed in among them until she was hidden completely from above. She crouched against the trunk. Her chest was heaving. Her wing was bleeding, not badly, but enough.

Above the canopy, she heard the goshawk wheel, once, twice. He did not see her. He did not leave.

Below — and she only realized this now, hidden among the leaves — was a small temple courtyard.

It was a quiet place. A small stone-paved square. A dry well in one corner. A stone bench. A small fire, with a kettle hanging over it. At the bench sat two people.

One was a very old man. His head was shaved smooth. His robe was the dust-grey of robes that have been washed too many times. His hands were folded in his lap. He sat, perfectly straight, looking at nothing in particular.

The other was a young man — barely more than a boy — kneeling on a mat at the old man's feet, with a book open in front of him. The boy was not looking at the book. He was looking up at the trees. His face was tight with fear.

"Master," the boy said. "There is a hawk above us."

"I heard him," said the old man.

"Should we — should we go inside?"

"No, Wen. We are doing well as we are."

"But — "

"Wen. Pour the water. Make the tea."

"Master — "

"Wen."

The boy fell silent. He picked up the kettle, with hands that trembled a little, and he poured the steaming water into a small clay pot. He stirred. He waited. He poured the tea into two small cups, one for the master and one for himself.

The master did not pick up his cup. Instead, he reached for a third cup that had been sitting upturned on the bench, and he set it upright next to the other two, and he poured tea into it as well. Three cups, in a row.

Then he sat back, and he closed his eyes, and he said:

"Wen. While the tea cools, I will tell you a story I heard from my own teacher when I was your age. A story about wisdom and war."

"A long time ago," the master said, "in a country very far north of here, there were two armies."

"This country?"

"Not this country. A different country. Be quiet."

The boy was quiet.

"Two armies, camped on two hills, with a small valley between them. Both armies had been sent by their kings. Both armies had been told they were defending the honor of their land. Both armies had soldiers who had wives at home, and children, and old fathers, and small fields they were missing the harvest of. Both armies had been camped on their hills for nine days, glaring at each other across the valley.

"On the tenth morning, they were going to fight.

"Now in the valley — and this is the part you have to imagine — there was an old man and his student. They had been walking through the country, on their way somewhere else. They had not known about the armies. They had walked into the valley the day before, looking for a place to rest. And there they were, one small old

man and one young student, between two great armies who were about to send arrows down on them from both sides.

"The student was terrified. He said: *Master, we should run. Now, before the morning comes. We can be miles away by sunrise.*

"The old man did not seem to hear him. He looked at the small fire they had made. He looked at the small kettle they had carried. He looked at the morning star, which was very bright that night.

"Then he said: *Sit, my friend. Boil water. We will make tea.*

"*Master — *

"*Sit. The water won't boil itself.*

"So the student sat. Because that was what the student did when his master told him to sit. And he boiled the water. And while the water was boiling, the dawn came up over the eastern hill, and the army on that hill saw, in the valley below, the small fire and the small old man and the small young student calmly preparing tea.

"They sent a scout.

"The scout came down the hill. He was an officer, in armor, with a sword. He arrived at the fire, breathing hard. He said: *Old man. Do you not know there is about to be a battle?*

"And the old man said: *Yes. That is why we are making tea. War makes men thirsty.*

"The scout stared. *Whose side are you on?*

"And the old man said: *I am on the side of whoever drinks tea with me first.*

"The scout did not know what to do with that. So he sat down, because he was tired, and the old man poured him tea, and he drank it. Then he went back up the hill to report.

"By now, the army on the *other* hill had also seen the small fire below. They sent their own scout. Same conversation. The scout drank tea. He went back.

"On both hills, the generals were puzzled. They sent their highest officers. The officers came down. The old man poured them tea. They drank. They went back.

"Eventually, both generals came down themselves, with their guards, and stood across the small fire from each other, glaring. Two great men, in armor, in helmets, with their swords drawn. And one small old man, sitting on the ground, with his cup of tea.

"The old man looked up.

"*Gentlemen,* he said. *Sit.*

"They did not sit. *Old man,* the western general said, *we are about to fight a war. Do not waste our time.*

"*I will not waste your time. May I ask why you are about to fight?*

"The western general said: *He has insulted us. He claimed our river. We must teach him.*

"The eastern general said: *He has insulted *us*.* He claimed our mountain. We must teach *him*.*

"The old man said: *May I ask which river? And which mountain?*

"They named them.

"And the old man said, very quietly: *I have walked along that river. I drank from it three days ago. It runs through both your lands. It has water enough for both. I have stood on that mountain. I climbed it last summer. It is wide. There are many paths up. There is room for both of you, and your sons after you, and your sons' sons. Neither of those things belongs to either of you, gentlemen. The river belongs to whoever is thirsty. The mountain belongs to whoever climbs it. Nobody owns water. Nobody owns stone. You are about to send ten thousand men to die for things that belong to no one.*

"He paused.

"*The tea,* he said, *belongs to whoever drinks it. The tea is real. The battle is not. Drink the tea, gentlemen, before the sun is too high.*

"There was a long, long silence.

"Then the western general — slowly — sat down. Then the eastern general sat down. They sat across the fire from each other. The old man poured tea for each of them, and they drank.

"And when the tea was finished, they looked at each other. And one of them — nobody quite remembers which one — said: *I have a son.*

"And the other said: *I have a son too.*

"And they did not say anything else. But they got up, and they went back to their armies, and they told their armies to break camp and go home.

"And the armies did. They had not been wanting to fight. They had only been told to.

"And the old man — when his student finally remembered to ask him — said only: *I did not do anything. I made tea. The tea did the rest.*"

The master finished the story.

The boy had not moved.

Above them, the goshawk had stopped circling. He had landed on the corner of the temple wall. He was perched there now, very still, watching. His fire-colored eyes were fixed on the boy. Story, hidden in the fig, could see him perfectly.

The master did not look up.

He picked up his cup. He drank his tea. He set the cup down. He picked up the second cup — Wen's — and he passed it gently to the boy. The boy took it with both shaking hands. He drank.

The master picked up the third cup. The one he had set out at the start. He held it up — without looking at the goshawk on the wall — and he said, in a voice not loud, not soft, just clear:

"Friend. There is tea here, if you would like some. It is hot. It is real. We have enough."

The goshawk did not move.

The master set the cup down at the edge of the bench, where any creature could come and have it. Then he turned, calmly, and continued to talk to Wen.

"The story," he said, "is not really about the armies. The story is about the tea. The world is full of things that men have decided to

fight about — rivers, and mountains, and slights, and old griefs. But the tea is real. The fire is real. The morning is real. When you cannot make the world stop fighting, Wen — and you will not always be able to — you can still make the tea. You can still sit down. You can still offer a cup. Sometimes the cup will be refused. Sometimes it will not. That is not your concern. Your concern is to keep making the tea. Do you understand?"

Wen was crying, very quietly. He nodded.

"Good. Drink your tea before it gets cold."

The boy drank.

On the wall, the goshawk shifted his weight. He looked at the third cup. He looked at the master. He looked up at the fig tree, and Story shrank back deeper into the leaves. Then he looked, again, at the master.

The master did not look at him.

The goshawk waited a very long time. Story counted her own heartbeats. They were the loudest thing in the courtyard.

At last, slowly, the goshawk opened his great wings. He pushed off the wall. He climbed once around the temple, in a long unhurried loop. And then he flew east, over the green hills, until he was a small dark spot against the sky, and then nothing.

He did not look back.

For a long time after the goshawk had gone, Story stayed where she was. She did not entirely trust that he was gone. She did not entirely trust that she was alive.

The master, below, drank his tea.

When she finally moved — when she shook out her wings and stepped out of the fig leaves into the open — the master did not seem surprised. He turned his head, slowly, toward the tree, and he said:

"Ah. Friend in the tree. Will you come down? There is the third cup. We do not ask why a guest is in our trees. We are only glad they came."

Story flew down. She landed shakily on the bench beside the third cup. The wound on her wing had stopped bleeding. The blood had dried into the feathers.

The master looked at her properly for the first time. His eyes were old and very kind.

"Ah," he said again. "Look at you."

He looked at the marks. The flames. The feathers. The waves. The stars. The fish. The vines. The figures. The dots. The silver crescents. The bronze ovals behind her eyes. She had stopped counting them. He, apparently, was counting now.

"Twelve."

"Yes, sir."

"And tonight you will carry thirteen, friend, because I think the small mark for this one has just begun."

He was right.

The warmth came. She felt it on her tail — at the base of her two longest tail feathers, the outermost ones, the ones a bird uses to steer in flight. A small heat gathered, on each side, and then stilled.

She turned and looked.

Two small, dark, perfect circles. One on the outermost tail feather on each side. Round as cups seen from above. Tea-bowl shape. The mark of a story about wisdom and war and the steam rising from a small fire in a valley.

The master saw them — Story turned to show him — and he laughed. It was the first laugh she had heard from him.

"Tea," he said. "Of course. Tea is the part you steer with."

He pushed the third cup toward her.

"Drink, friend. Before it's cold."

Story dipped her beak in. The tea was warm and bitter and earthy and very, very good.

She stayed at the temple for two days while her wing healed. Wen brought her small offerings of cooked rice and fish from the kitchen, and once a small cricket he had caught in the garden, which she ate with great dignity though she would have preferred a mouse. The master came and went on his slow rounds. Sometimes she would look up from her perch on the bench and find him watching her with the same calm, patient gaze he had used on the goshawk. He never said much. Once he said: *Tell me one of yours, friend.* And she told him about the silver fish that pulled the sun out of the dark, the way the fisherman by the great river had told it. And the master had said: *Yes. That is a true one.* And nothing more.

On the third morning her wing was strong. She thanked the master. She thanked Wen. She thanked the third cup, which they had

now set out for her every meal.

She flew west again, into the green hills.

But she flew slower than she had been. She had a thing to think about.

She thought about the goshawk on the wall. About how he had been hungry, and tired, and probably hunted himself, somewhere, by something larger. About how he had not been a monster. About how the master had not, even for a moment, treated him as one.

She thought about her grandmother in the hollow. *Most of them will be Medusas.*

She thought about the tea.

And she decided, as she rose into the warm afternoon air over the rice fields, that for the rest of her flying life — however long it lasted, however far it took her — she would try to keep a third cup ready. For whoever came. For whatever was watching. For the friend she did not know was in the tree.

The two small dark circles on her tail flashed, once, in the sun.

Then she flew on.

End of Chapter Ten.

Chapter Eleven: The Singing

After the temple, Story flew west.

For weeks. Then for months.

The wisdom of the master with the third cup was settling in her, slowly, the way a deep teaching does — not in a moment but over many evenings. She had begun, in her own small way, to keep a third cup ready. On long flights she made a point of stopping at unlikely places — old barns, lonely trees, abandoned lookouts — and just sitting there a while. So that any creature who happened to be hiding nearby would know there was a quiet owl present, and a quiet owl is not the same as a hunting owl, and a passing rest is sometimes a kind of welcome.

She had not yet found anyone in particular doing so. But she did it anyway.

She thought, sometimes, that the master had quietly given her her work.

She had passed beyond the country of the rice fields. She had crossed the great brown rivers, and the high plateaus, and a country of tall grass where the only sound for days was the wind. Then mountains, and more mountains. She had been heading, vaguely, toward a country further west where she had been told there were old, old stories — stories from before there were even alphabets — but she was not sure if she would get that far before she had to turn back.

And she was tired.

Not in her wings. Her wings had become strong over the past year, the way the heron had said they would. She could fly all night and not feel it.

It was a different tiredness. A tiredness in the place where she carried the marks.

She had been doing this — *being a Story Owl* — for what felt like a very long time. And lately, on quiet nights, she had begun to wonder a thing she did not say out loud, even to herself, because saying it would make it true.

She had begun to wonder if any of it mattered.

If anyone, anywhere, was actually different because of the stories she had carried. If the chain she was part of — the long chain of grandmothers and fishermen and herons and tea-masters — was just a long chain of small efforts that, when you looked at them clearly, had not really changed the world at all.

She did not believe it, exactly. But the thought was there, and it would not leave.

The storm came the way storms come in high mountains. Without much warning. A cold, hard, white-grey storm. Wet snow at first, then dry. Then wind that felt like hands shoving her sideways. Then nothing she could see at all.

She tried to fly with it. You cannot fly *against* a mountain storm. You fly with it, and you try to land before it kills you.

It carried her for a long time. Hours, perhaps. She lost all sense of direction. She felt the air go thin under her, the way it had the first

time she had crossed the Andes. She knew she had been pushed high. She didn't know how high.

When the storm finally let go of her — when it set her down, in the way storms do, as if it had gotten bored with the toy — she found herself on a steep slope of stones and small thorny bushes, in a part of the world she could not name.

She was very cold. Her feathers were rimed with ice.

She looked around for shelter.

And there, fifty wing-lengths down the slope, half-tucked into a fold of the mountain, was a small wooden building.

Smoke was coming out of its chimney.

She made it to the door — staggered, really, the last few feet — and the door opened before she could even knock against it.

An old woman was standing there.

She was small. Almost as small as Story herself, in the way some very old people become small. Her face was a network of fine lines. Her hair was white and braided in a single long braid down her back. She wore many layers — a felt vest over a wool tunic, leggings of some hide, soft boots. Around her neck was a string of beads of many colors, faded and old.

She did not seem surprised that an owl had appeared at her door in a storm.

She stepped aside.

"Come in," she said. Or she said something. Story could not understand the words. But the meaning was clear.

Story stepped in.

The room was small and warm. A single low table. A pallet bed in one corner. A small iron stove with a kettle. A shelf with a few jars and bowls. A small wooden carving on the windowsill — some kind of animal, a horse maybe, very simple, worn smooth by handling. The air smelled of woodsmoke and something earthy, like buttered grain.

The old woman gestured Story toward the stove.

Story went. She crouched by it. Her feathers slowly began to thaw.

The old woman went back to what she had been doing, which was stirring something in a small wooden bowl. She did it without looking at Story again. As if having an owl by her stove in a storm was a perfectly ordinary thing. As if she had been expecting visitors of one kind or another, and one had come, and that was that.

And as she stirred, she sang.

It was the singing Story noticed first.

It was very quiet. So quiet that at first she thought it was just the woman's breathing. But it was singing. A thin, old voice, a little ragged at the edges, holding a long slow tune that Story did not know.

The words — if there were words — were in no language Story had ever heard. They might not have been words at all. They might

have been the kind of singing that has long since stopped using words and become just sound, just shape, just the *manner* of singing that one family had used for a very long time.

The old woman sang while she stirred. She sang while she trimmed the lamp. She sang while she added a stick to the stove. She sang while she set a small clay bowl of grain and butter on the floor beside Story, who was now warm enough to eat, and who ate gratefully.

She sang while she ate her own bowl, with one hand, slowly, the way very old people eat.

She sang while she lit a small candle in a little dish, and set it on the windowsill beside the carved wooden horse.

She sang while the storm howled outside.

She sang and sang and sang.

And Story, watching her — with her great owl ears tuned to small sounds across continents — began to understand.

This was not just a song the old woman knew. This was a song she had to *keep going*.

There was no one else in the hut. There was no one else, by the look of it, in this whole part of the mountain — Story had seen no other dwelling on her way down. The old woman lived alone. She had probably lived alone for a long time.

And the song —

The song belonged to her family. To her people. To a line of singers who had been singing it, every day, for so long that nobody remembered what the words meant or why it was being sung. They

only knew it had to keep going. That if it ever stopped — really stopped — something would be lost. Something more than the song.

She was the last of them.

Story knew this not because the old woman had said anything, but because the old woman had not said anything, and because the song was being sung the way you sing when you are the only voice left.

Slow. Continuous. Carefully. As if you are the only person in the room holding up something very heavy.

The storm went on for hours. Outside, the wind threw snow against the windows. Inside, the old woman sang.

And Story thought about the thing she had been carrying for weeks. The tiredness. The doubt. The quiet wondering whether any of this mattered.

And then she thought about the marks on her belly. The curling green vines. The ones she had not looked at in a long time. The story she had gathered, years ago now, deep in a jungle far to the south, listening from the rafters of a thatched house while a small jungle girl told her grandmother a story she had only just learned herself.

She thought: *I should tell her.*

She did not know if the old woman would understand. She did not know if an owl and an old woman could understand each other, even in a moment like this. But she had been carrying that story for years, and she had never told it to anyone, and tonight there was someone in front of her who needed exactly that story.

She had learned, by now, to trust this feeling.

She walked, on her two clumsy owl feet, to the foot of the old woman's bed. She fluttered up onto the post. She settled there. She looked at the old woman across the small warm room.

The old woman looked back. She did not stop singing.

But she tilted her head a little. As if to listen.

And Story began.

"A long time ago," she said —

"There was a time when the sky was very low.

"So low that the tallest people had to stoop. So low that the elephants and the giraffes had to crouch. So low that the great cats, when they yawned, almost touched it. So low that the birds could not really fly — they could only flutter, close to the ground, never properly *up*.

"And the sun was so close it hurt the eyes. And the moon was so close you could see all its bumps and craters. And the clouds dragged along the tops of the trees, leaving wet rags caught in the branches.

"The world was warm. The world was crowded. The world was *full*.

"And the people who lived in it did not know it was wrong. They had never known anything else. But there was a feeling everybody had — of being too close to everything. Of not enough space. Of wanting, somehow, to *stretch*.

"They did not have a word for it. They just had the feeling.

"And one day — and this is the part the grandmother always told with great care, because it is the most important part — a small girl found a seed.

"She didn't know what kind of seed. It was round, and brown, and ordinary. She would have thrown it away. But something made her stop. She held it in her palm. And she felt the seed *wanting to grow.*

"So she planted it. In a small bare spot of dirt outside her village.

"The seed sprouted overnight. By morning it was a thin green shoot, no bigger than her finger.

"By the next day it was the size of a child.

"By the next week it was taller than the tallest hut in the village.

"The people came to see. Some said it should be cut down — it would block the sun, which was already too close. Others said it should be left alone — it was clearly something special. The girl said: *Don't cut it. It's growing for a reason.* And because it was her seed, they let her.

"The tree kept growing.

"After a month it was taller than the tallest tree in the jungle.

"After a year it was so tall they couldn't see its top.

"And then — slowly — slowly — something began to happen.

"As the tree grew, the sky began to lift.

"Not all at once. Not in a way you could see in a day. But week by week, season by season, the sky climbed higher. The sun rose to where the sun is now. The moon climbed to where the moon is now. The clouds rose to where the clouds are. The tallest people stood up

straight for the first time, and they remembered, suddenly, that they had always been meant to. The elephants raised their heads. The giraffes stretched out their long necks and walked tall. The great cats yawned without fear of hitting anything.

"And the birds —

"The birds spread their wings and flew. Properly. *Up*. Into the high empty sky that had just been made.

"The tree had been pushing up the sky.

"It kept growing. It grew through the layer of clouds, and the clouds went higher. It grew through the layer where the birds flew, and the birds went higher still. It grew until its branches were among the stars, and then it kept growing past them. And where its leaves brushed against the dark of space — every leaf — every leaf became a star, and stayed there, and shone.

"That is why the sky is full of stars. They are the leaves of the tree that held up the sky."

She paused.

The old woman was very still. She had stopped stirring. She had not stopped singing — but the singing had become quieter, almost just a hum, an undertone beneath Story's voice.

"But here is the part," Story said, "that the grandmother always told. The tree did not grow on its own.

"The tree grew because the small girl — the one who had planted it — sang to it every night.

"She sang to it with her small voice. The songs her grandmother had taught her. The songs she made up. The songs of her village. The

songs nobody else remembered anymore. She sang them, one after another, every night of her life. While the tree grew.

"And if she ever stopped, the tree would stop growing. And the sky would come down again.

"So she sang. Every night of her life. Until she was a young woman. Until she was a grown woman. Until she was a grandmother herself. Until she was an old, old woman.

"And when she died, her granddaughter took up the song.

"And when *she* died, *her* granddaughter took up the song.

"And so on, and so on. There has been a song singing somewhere on earth, every single night, since the first night the seed was planted. Sometimes it is sung in a village. Sometimes by a child alone in a forest. Sometimes by an old woman in a hut on a mountain. Sometimes only by one person in the whole world.

"But it has never stopped.

"Because if it ever does — if it ever stops, even for one night — the tree will stop growing.

"And the sky will start to come down again."

Story's voice trailed off.

The hut was very quiet.

The wind had died, outside. The storm had passed.

The old woman was looking at her. Her dark eyes were enormous, and wet, and old, and they were looking right at Story.

She had stopped singing.

For one terrible second, Story thought: *what have I done. I've made her stop.*

But then —

The old woman started again.

She did not pick up where she had left off. She started somewhere new — somewhere deeper — the way a person starts a song they have not sung in a long time at the proper beginning. Her voice was stronger now. Not loud. But steady. Carrying. As if some weight she had been holding had shifted, just a little, into the part of her shoulders that could carry it best.

She sang the whole thing through, while Story listened.

It was long. It went on, with rises and falls, with pauses, with little held notes that the old woman seemed to be remembering as she went. It had no words Story could understand. But it had a *shape* — Story could feel it — the shape of being passed, mother to daughter, grandmother to grandchild, for many, many generations.

When she had finished, she folded her hands in her lap and closed her eyes.

She did not cry. She did not smile. She just sat.

And Story felt the warmth come.

It was at the base of her neck. Where her body met her shoulders. Just under where a person might wear a necklace.

Two small, thin, vertical lines. One on the left, one on the right. Mirrored. Like threads, or like a single hair from a long braid, or like

the line of a song descending.

She turned her head to look. The old woman opened her eyes and looked too.

Then — without speaking — the old woman reached up to her own neck, and unhooked the string of faded beads, and held them out.

Story stepped forward and bowed her head.

The old woman, very gently, slipped the string of beads over Story's head. The beads were small and warm from her body. They settled around her neck. They sat against the new marks, the two thin vertical lines, like a song against the thread that carried it.

"There," said the old woman.

She had not said anything since opening the door. Story did not understand the word. But that was all right.

She thought she understood the word.

In the morning the storm was completely gone.

The sky over the mountain was the high, cold, washed blue of after-storm. The snow on the slope was deep and bright. There was no sound anywhere.

Story stepped out of the door of the hut. The old woman stood in the doorway and watched her go. She did not wave. Owls do not wave back.

Story flew.

The string of beads sat warm at her throat. The two new marks sat under it.

She climbed up out of the valley, slowly, the way she climbed now — like a Story Owl, not like an ordinary one. She got to the top of the ridge. She turned, in the cold blue air, and looked back at the small hut, with its small chimney, with its small smoke rising into the cold blue sky.

And from inside, very faintly, she heard the singing.

Steady. Carrying. Long and slow.

The tree, she thought, was still growing.

And so was she.

She turned west, into the morning, and flew on.

End of Chapter Eleven.

Chapter Twelve: The Fifth Sun

She left the singing woman's mountain and flew on.

Years passed.

Time moved in a particular way for Story now. The wind brought spring and then summer and then autumn and then winter. She crossed the grass-country, and the desert-country, and the country of cedars. She crossed an ocean — a real one this time, not just a lake — and she rested on small wet islands of rock that rose up out of the dark blue for no reason except that her wings needed somewhere to be.

Then she crossed another country, dense with green. Then jungle. Then a country of valleys and tall stone hills. The air smelled of dry earth and old smoke.

She had been a Story Owl for a long time now. The faded beads at her throat had grown smooth. The two small thread-lines under them had darkened in. Sometimes when she stretched her wings she would catch sight of her own body — the flames, the feathers, the waves, the stars, the vines, the figures, the dots, the silver crescents, the bronze ovals, the tea-bowls, the thread-lines — and she would feel a small surprise. As if she had not quite gotten used to herself yet. As if every time she looked, there was a little more to look at.

There were a few more, even since the mountain. A weaver's family song from a coast where the sea was warm. A boy's story about a dog. A bee-keeper's story about a sister who had become an old apple tree. They had each added their own neat little marks in their own neat little places.

But she was, for the first time, also beginning to feel her age.

Not in a sad way. She was strong. Her wings still beat well. Her ears still heard everything. But she felt the years now, the way the heron at the marsh, long ago, had felt them.

She was no longer young.

The land she was over now was a dry one. Brown hills under a hard blue sky. A scatter of low trees. And in the long shallow valley below — rising up out of the ground in the late afternoon light — were three enormous shapes of stone.

Pyramids.

She had never seen anything like them. They were the size of small mountains. Their sides were stepped, like enormous staircases climbing up to flat tops. The stone was the color of dry earth, and the dust of the road that wound past them was the same color too.

She circled, slowly, in the warm afternoon air.

Two of the pyramids were ruined — half-collapsed, their stones tumbled into the grass, with small trees growing out of the cracks. One stood whole. Below it was a small village of low houses with red-tiled roofs, and threads of smoke rising from kitchen fires. Children were running between the houses. Old women were carrying baskets. A line of people, dressed in clean white, was beginning to assemble at the foot of the standing pyramid, as if they were about to climb.

A ceremony, she thought. They are about to do a thing they have done for a long time.

She glided down toward a cluster of old trees at the edge of the village. She was tired enough that she landed less gracefully than she had meant to — she clipped a branch, came down with a small thump on the next one, and had to grip hard not to slip off.

She settled.

Below her, very close, was a fire.

Around the fire sat an old man, three small children, and one quiet girl who looked a little older than the small ones but younger than the line of people getting ready at the pyramid.

The girl looked up.

She had seen Story land. Story knew she had. The girl's dark eyes were fixed on her, calmly, with no surprise.

But the girl did not say anything. She just kept looking. After a moment, she went back to listening to the old man.

The old man had been talking. He was talking now.

He had not seen Story.

"Grandfather," one of the small children said, "tell us the story before we go up."

"Which one?"

"The one about the suns."

"You've heard it many times."

"Tell us again."

The old man laughed — a small, dry, kind laugh — and stirred the fire with a long stick.

"Very well. Sit. Don't put your foot in the embers."

He waited until they had settled. The quiet older girl tucked her knees under her chin. She had not looked up at Story again, but she had not forgotten her either. Story could tell by the angle of her head.

"A long, long, *long* time ago," the old man began, "before this world that we live in — there was another world. And before that one, another. And before that, another. And before that, *another*.

"Four worlds. Four suns. Each one came and went.

"The first sun was a sun of jaguars. In that world, great cats walked the earth. They were the strongest creatures alive. They ruled everything. But after a long time, the jaguars ate too much of the world, and the world ended. The first sun went out.

"The second sun was a sun of wind. In that world, the air was always moving. There were great storms every day. The world was beautiful but restless. After a long time, the wind blew so hard that even the mountains came loose, and the world ended. The second sun went out.

"The third sun was a sun of fire. In that world, fire came down from the sky like rain. The people of that world were brave, but they could not live where it was always burning. After a long time, the fire took everything. The third sun went out.

"The fourth sun was a sun of water. In that world, the rivers ran high, and the seas crept up, and even the birds had to live on the tallest mountains. After a long time, the water rose over everything. The fourth sun went out.

"And then the gods gathered."

He paused. He looked at the children.

"After four suns going out, the gods were tired. They were also worried. They knew it was time for a new sun, but they did not know how to make one. And they did not want to make this one wrong.

"They gathered at a place we still call Teotihuacan, which means *the place where gods become.* It is not too far from here. One day you will see it.

"At Teotihuacan, they built a great fire. Bigger than any fire that had ever burned. So hot that even the gods could not stand close to it.

"And they asked: *who will leap into the fire? Who will give themselves to become the new sun?*

"There was a long silence.

"Then a god stepped forward. His name was Tecuciztecatl."

The old man pronounced it slowly. *Te-cu-cis-te-CATL.* The small children tried to repeat it and giggled.

"He was rich. He was proud. He was dressed in feathers of green quetzal, and gold, and jade. He bowed to the other gods and said: *I will become the sun.*

"The other gods nodded. They were impressed. They had expected someone grand to volunteer, and here he was — grand. As grand as could be.

"But then a *second* god stepped forward.

"His name was Nanahuatzin."

The old man pronounced this one carefully too. *Na-na-HUA-tzin.*

"He was *not* rich. He was *not* proud. He was the smallest, humblest god in the gathering. He was covered, all over his body, in small sores — little pustules, the kind a sick person gets — and he was ashamed of them. He had nothing fine to offer. He had only a few reeds, and some thorns, and the marks on his own skin.

"He bowed his small head to the other gods and said, very quietly: *I will also leap.*

"And the gods — to their credit — did not laugh. They said: *very well. You will both try.*

"They lit the great fire.

"Tecuciztecatl, the proud one, stepped up first. He looked into the fire. He spread his magnificent arms. He prepared to leap.

"And then —

"He stopped.

"The fire was very hot. Hotter than he had imagined. He felt it on his face. He stepped back. He gathered himself. He tried again. He stepped up. He prepared to leap.

"And then — again — he stopped.

"The other gods watched. They did not say anything.

"He tried a third time. He could not do it. The fire was too big. The leap was too far.

"He tried a fourth time. He could not do it.

"And the proud god stepped back, ashamed, his beautiful feathers trembling, and he did not look anyone in the eye.

"Nanahuatzin's turn.

"The small humble god stepped up to the fire. He did not look at the other gods. He did not say anything. He did not even take a breath, the storytellers say. He just walked to the edge of the fire —

"and he leapt."

The old man stopped.

The fire by his foot popped.

The smallest of the children whispered: "Did he — "

"He did. He went into the fire. And in the fire he was changed. And up out of the smoke — slowly — rose the new sun. *Our* sun. The fifth one. The one that is still in the sky now.

"And when the rest of the gods looked at what had happened — when they saw the small humble god become the sun that would warm every grandfather, and every child, and every fire-builder for thousands and thousands of years — they understood, suddenly, what they had missed.

"And Tecuciztecatl, the proud one, watching it happen, was so ashamed that he also ran forward and leapt.

"And he, too, was changed.

"And up he rose, beside the new sun. *Also* shining. *Also* warm. *Also* beautiful.

"But — and this is the part you must remember, little ones — because he had hesitated, and because he had not been the first, he did not become a second sun. He became the *moon*.

"The other gods, looking at him, decided that even the moon was too bright for someone who had hesitated. So they threw a small

rabbit at his face, to dim him. The rabbit struck him gently and stayed. If you look at the moon, on a clear night, you can still see the rabbit. It is the dark shape that humans in other countries pretend is a man. It is not a man. It is a rabbit. We can see better than they can."

The small children giggled.

"And the new sun and the new moon hung in the sky. But — and this is the very last thing — they did not move.

"They just sat there.

"And the other gods, looking up at them, realized that the world was not finished yet. The sun and moon had to *travel*. The day had to come and go. The night had to come and go. And in order for that to happen, the gods understood, *they* would also have to give something. Not just Nanahuatzin. Not just Tecuciztecatl. All of them.

"So they gave. Each in their own way. Each one of them set down something they had been carrying, and each one of them changed, and from each one of them a little more of the world's motion was made. The wind that blows. The rain that falls. The seasons that turn. The animals that walk. All of it. The gods gave themselves, piece by piece, to make the world move.

"That is why we are here. That is why this fire burns. That is why the sun set just a little while ago, and will rise again in the morning. Because the gods leapt. *Every one of them.*

"And the smallest, humblest one leapt first."

The old man was quiet a moment.

"That," he said, "is why we climb the pyramid. To say thank you. We climb up to where the sun nearly meets us, and we sit there for a

little while, and we remember."

He looked at the children. He looked at the older quiet girl. He looked, almost, but not quite, at Story in her tree.

"Time to go up," he said. "Tlali — " — and that was the quiet girl — "you stay here with me a moment longer. Keep the fire. Send the smoke up the right way."

Tlali nodded.

The small children scrambled up and ran toward the procession at the base of the pyramid, where the line of people in white was beginning, slowly, to start the climb.

The old man rose. His old knees creaked. He took up a small bundle of herbs from beside the fire — sweet-smelling, dry — and set them carefully in the embers. The smoke began to rise white and fragrant into the cold dry evening.

He looked at Tlali. He set a hand on her shoulder.

"You'll do well."

He limped after the children, toward the pyramid.

Tlali sat by the fire alone.

The fire crackled. Tlali tended it. The smoke went up white and clean.

But the smallest of the children had not gone all the way to the procession. She had stopped near the edge of it, and turned, and toddled back, the way the very small sometimes do. She wanted to come back to her sister.

Tlali did not see her. She was bent over the fire, adjusting the bundle of herbs.

The little one did not come to the fire. She had seen something — maybe a beetle, maybe a bright stone — and had turned aside. She was walking toward the dark mouth of an old stone well at the edge of the field. It was the kind of well that goes deep into the earth. Generations of villagers had used it. It was uncovered.

She walked toward it, watching her own feet.

Story saw it from her tree.

She did not think.

She did not have a small voice in her head saying: *should I do this? what is safe? what will happen?* The way she had had small voices in her head, many times, on many of her travels. There were no voices this time. There was only one of the smallest children, walking toward a deep dark well, and only one creature in the field who could see her doing it.

Story leapt.

She fell from the branch like a stone — like Nanahuatzin into the fire — and her wings caught the air, and she shot across the field low and silent, and she landed between the little girl and the well, two great wing-spans before the edge.

She spread her wings. Wide. As wide as they would go. The flames on her chest, the feathers on her shoulders, the waves on her wings, the silver crescents at her wing-tips — all of it was suddenly facing the little girl, who stopped walking, and stared, and forgot completely about the well.

Story hooted. One big, deep, slow hoot. Louder than she usually hooted. The kind of hoot that travels.

By the fire, Tlali looked up.

She saw, all at once: her little sister, three steps from the open well; the great owl spread wide in front of her; the dust still settling around them both.

Tlali was on her feet in an instant. She crossed the field at a run. She scooped her sister up. She held her. She did not scold. She was breathing too hard to scold. She just held.

Tlali looked at Story.

Story stood her ground. She did not back away, but she did not come closer either. Her wings were still half-spread.

Tlali was breathing hard.

In her culture, an owl meant something. A messenger. Sometimes from places people did not like to think about. Tlali had been told, all her life, to be careful around owls. To listen if one called near the house at night, because it might be warning of something. To not look too directly.

But this owl had just saved her sister.

Tlali looked at Story with eyes that were trying very hard to see clearly. After a long moment she said, in a low voice:

"You jumped."

Story did not move.

"You jumped," Tlali said again. "Like the small humble god."

Story took one step forward. Tlali did not flinch.

The fire was still smoking behind them. The procession on the pyramid was still climbing, far off, unaware. The little sister had buried her face in Tlali's shoulder and was looking sideways at Story with one bright eye.

After a long time, Tlali whispered: "Thank you."

Story dipped her head.

It was then that she felt the warmth come.

Not on her chest. Not on her belly. On the underside of each wing — on the inside surface, just where the wing folded close to her body, where they were tucked away from view in ordinary flight. A small heat gathered on each side. Then it stilled.

She did not need to look. She knew already, somehow.

She opened her wings — slowly, the way one shows something — and Tlali drew a breath in.

Two small dark shapes, mirrored. One on the inside of each wing. Curled, mid-leap. Long ears tucked back. Short tail. Quick legs.

Rabbits.

Like the one in the moon.

The grandfather came at a slow run. He had heard the hoot. He had come back from the foot of the pyramid as fast as his old legs would carry him.

He saw Tlali. He saw her little sister. He saw the well. He saw Story.

He stopped.

He looked at Story for a long time.

Then he came over — slowly, calmly, the way you come over to a creature who has just done something extraordinary and might still leave — and he stood beside his granddaughter. He looked at the great owl, with her wings still half-open, and at the two small rabbit-shapes that had appeared inside them.

He said, very quietly: "Look at that."

He looked at Tlali. "You saw it?"

"I saw it."

"She jumped."

"Like Nanahuatzin."

"Yes."

He turned back to Story. He bowed — not all the way, not the formal way, but a small inclination of the old gray head. The kind of bow you give to someone you respect.

"Welcome to our valley, little jumper," he said. "Eat at our fire tonight, if you like. Sleep in our trees. Stay as long as you wish. You have given us back something we very nearly lost."

Story did not stay long. She rested by the fire for a while, while Tlali sat with her sister, and the grandfather added more herbs to the embers, and the smoke went up white and fragrant. Far off, the procession reached the top of the pyramid, and a single thin chant began to rise into the cold dry air — very small from this distance,

but very clear.

After the chant had ended, Story rose, and shook out her wings, and looked once at Tlali.

Tlali raised one hand.

Story climbed.

She got high enough to see the whole valley — the three pyramids, the village, the fire by the trees, the line of people coming back down again in the last of the sunset's light. She turned west.

She thought, as she went, of the small humble god who had not hesitated. Of the proud god who had. Of all the others who had given themselves, after, so that the sun and moon could move. Of the silver fish, pulling the sun up in the morning. Of the small girl in a jungle, singing every night to the tree that held up the sky. Of every grandfather telling every story. Of every Story Owl who had ever flown.

She thought: *We are all leaping.*

And she went on.

End of Chapter Twelve.

Chapter Thirteen: She Who Stays

She flew south.

Down the long spine of mountains that ran like the backbone of the world. Past the valley of pyramids, past dry country, past jungle, until she was once again in the high cold air she had crossed many years before, in the country of the fox who had tried to take the moon.

Something had happened to her, somewhere in the leaving of the pyramid valley. She did not know when, exactly. She only noticed it slowly.

Her wings — which had begun to feel the years — stopped feeling them. Her ears — which had begun to soften — stayed sharp. The small grey that had started to come in at her ear-tufts did not come in further. The faint stiffness she had felt, sometimes, in the cold mornings, was gone.

She did not age.

She did not know why. She did not know if it was because of the rabbits she now carried on the inside of her wings, or because of the small bronze mirrors behind her eyes, or because she had crossed too many stories and too many marks and her body had simply, quietly, decided to wait. To stay. To carry what she carried for as long as it needed carrying.

She found she did not mind.

There was so much left to gather. So much still to tell.

She kept going.

She came one evening over a high empty pass, and on a flat ridge of stone she saw a woman.

The woman was not moving.

She was very tall. She was wearing a long robe carved in fine folds. Her hair was very long, falling in two heavy braids down her back. She stood with her arms crossed over her chest. She was looking east, toward where the sun would rise.

She had been standing there for a long time. Story could see that.

Story landed on a stone several wing-spans away, and watched her.

The woman did not turn.

After a long while, Story understood.

The woman was made of stone.

A pale stone, the color of old bone, carved with such care that from a distance, in the dying light, you would have sworn she was breathing. The carving was old. Story could see the small places where the wind had worn her smooth, where the rain had darkened her shoulders, where moss had begun to climb up her left foot in a slow green tide.

She was a kind of waiting.

Story walked closer.

She was beautifully made. Her face was calm. Her eyes were closed. Her mouth was almost smiling, in the way of someone who is holding still on purpose because the thing they are waiting for is

worth it.

Story sat near her feet.

The wind moved across the ridge. Somewhere far below, a guanaco called. A condor passed overhead, slowly, the way condors pass.

Story did not know what to do with her.

She wanted, suddenly, to tell her something. She did not know why. Perhaps because the woman had been alone on this ridge for so long. Perhaps because she was so clearly, so terribly, *waiting*. So she told her a small one. About the swallow in the barn, and the song the swallow had made. About waiting being what flying *is*, the rest of the time.

She told it quietly, the way you tell a thing to someone who is sleeping.

She did not expect any answer. She did not get one.

But far up the ridge, where Story had not noticed him before, an old herder appeared with three alpacas and a tall walking stick. He stopped a polite distance away.

When Story finally turned her head, he called across the wind in a language she did not know.

She understood the gesture, though. *Come down. Sit lower than her.*

Story flew down to a lower rock. The herder came up and stood by the stone woman's foot. He laid one hand on her ankle, gently, as if greeting a very old friend.

He looked at Story.

"My grandmother told me about her," he said — and now the words came in a tongue Story could follow, the way some old languages come to you when you have flown long enough. "Her grandmother told her. My granddaughter will tell hers. She is the woman who chose to stay.

"Long ago — before the fall, before everything — there was someone who wanted to take her away from this place. She did not want to go. She loved the mountain. She loved her people. She loved the sky over this ridge. So she asked the Apu to make her stone. She said: *as long as I am here, the mountain remembers. As long as I am here, the sky knows where to come back to.*

"She has been here ever since. Through everything. Through the fall of our empire. Through the long bad years. Through the slow good ones. Through the children of children of children of children. She has stayed.

"And as long as she stays, the mountain remembers her. And so do we."

The old man patted the stone woman's ankle, the way you pat the flank of a tired horse. Then he turned to go.

But before he went, he looked at Story once more, and at the small dark shapes of rabbits she had not realized he could see from this distance.

"You've come a long way, little jumper."

He bowed once, the way the grandfather in the valley of pyramids had bowed, and walked off down the ridge with his alpacas, and disappeared into the dusk.

Story stayed on the ridge through the night.

She felt the warmth come, in a place that surprised her — high on her back, between her shoulders, where she could not easily see. She did not need to.

She knew the shape.

Two small upright stones, mirrored. One on each side. Standing patient between her wings, where they could only be seen by a creature flying directly above her — which would mean a creature larger than she was, which would mean very few creatures in the world. Marks for the eyes of condors. Marks for the things that look down.

She sat on her low rock through the dark hours and looked at the stone woman in the moonlight, and she thought: *this is what I will do. For as long as I can. I will gather. I will tell. I will keep coming back, the way she keeps standing here.*

In the morning the sun rose, slowly, over the ridge.

The stone woman's face — turned east for six hundred years — caught the first light.

She did not move.

But Story saw, in that moment, the smallest curl at the corner of her stone mouth.

Like she was, just barely, satisfied.

Story flew on.

End of Chapter Thirteen.

Chapter Fourteen: The Chameleon

Story flew east across an ocean she did not know.

She had been south. Far south. She had spent some time on the great grasslands, and a longer time in the deep green country with the river the size of an inland sea, and a longer time still in dry country with strange tall thin trees. Eventually the land had run out, and there had only been ocean ahead, and she had crossed it.

It took a long time.

She did not get tired the way she used to. Her wings carried her now the way wind carries a feather — effortlessly, mostly without her noticing. When she landed on islands she rested for the form of it, more than the need.

She came to the eastern shore of Africa one morning at dawn, in a country of mangroves and small wooden boats. The water was the color of glass. The fishermen waved at her without surprise. She flew on, inland, over rice paddies and brown rivers and stands of palms and, at last, into a country of grass and scattered enormous trees — trees with trunks like elephants, branches like roots, thicker than any tree she had seen.

Baobabs.

She had heard the name once, far away, from someone who had told her you could not really understand a baobab until you sat in one. She had not understood at the time. She did now.

She landed in the highest crook of the biggest one she could find.

The tree was very old. She could feel the age of it — the slow, deep, patient age that the great mountains had, but warmer, alive. The bark was thick and silvered. Inside the hollow of the trunk, somewhere below her, she could hear water dripping. The baobab held water inside itself; she remembered hearing this. They were almost like wells.

From the high crook she could see for many miles. Grass. More baobabs. A small village, perhaps a mile to the south, with thatched roofs and smoke rising. A red road winding away.

She thought: *I will stay a while.*

She did stay a while.

She watched the village come and go through several days. Women carrying water from a well. Children running between the houses. Men working in fields. Goats. Chickens. A small school with a battered tin roof. A larger building where, in the evenings, music came on — very faint from the baobab, mostly bass, a kind of drumming.

On the fifth evening, she noticed something new.

In the central clearing of the village, just before sunset, an old woman sat down on a low stool. She was very dark. Her hair was almost white, plaited tight to her head. She was wearing a wrapped cloth of orange and yellow and a brown shawl. She set her stool by a small fire.

Children began to gather around her.

First two, then four, then a dozen, then perhaps fifteen. They sat on the ground in front of her. The smaller ones sat in the laps of the bigger ones.

The old woman waited until they had settled. Then she clapped her hands once, gently. The children responded with the same clap. It was a thing she always did. They were always ready.

She began to speak.

She was too far for Story to hear. So Story did the thing she had become good at, over many years: she flew very quietly, in long careful glides, from baobab to baobab toward the edge of the village, until she was perched in the leaves of a small mango tree at the back of the clearing, listening.

The old woman was telling a story.

"There was once a girl," the grandmother began, "in a village not very different from ours, who did not want to grow up.

"She was happy as a child. She loved her mother. She loved her father. She loved her brothers and sisters and her uncles and her grandmother, who was, at the time, the storyteller of her village. As I am the storyteller of ours.

"She loved the river that ran past the village. She loved the way the sun came through the leaves in the morning. She loved running in the dust with the boys. She loved everything she had, every day, of her childhood.

"But her body began to change.

"She got taller. Her voice changed. Her interests began to shift. She found herself thinking about things she had not thought about before. The older women of the village began to look at her differently. They began to expect things from her. They began to say: *soon she will be a woman.*

"The girl did not want to be a woman. She wanted to stay a girl. She wanted *everything to stay the same forever*.

"So she did a thing children sometimes do — she refused. She refused to do the work her mother asked her to do. She refused to learn the things her grandmother tried to teach her. She refused to take part in the small ways the village was, day by day, trying to shape her into the woman it needed her to become.

"She thought if she refused hard enough, she could stop the changing.

"One day, when she had refused so many things and been so unkind for so long that her mother could not stand to be in the same hut with her, the girl went down to the river. She sat on a flat stone in the late sun. She put her chin in her hands. She was angry. She was sad. She did not know how to say what was wrong with her.

"She felt something move on the stone beside her.

"It was a chameleon."

The grandmother paused. Several of the children laughed — the chameleon was an expected character. They had heard the story before, the way children have heard their favorite stories before.

"The chameleon was green. It was sitting on a green leaf beside her, and it was just exactly the color of the leaf, so the girl had not seen it at first. She looked at it. The chameleon looked back.

"Then, very slowly, the chameleon stepped off the leaf and onto the gray flat stone. And as it walked, it changed. Its green melted away, slowly. It became gray. Gray as the stone. It blended in completely.

"The girl had seen chameleons her whole life. She had played with them. She had carried them in her hands. But she had never quite watched one *do* it before. She watched it now.

"After a little while, when the chameleon was completely gray, she said to it: *why are you always changing?*

"And the chameleon said: *I am not always changing. I am one color at a time. The color depends on where I am.*

"The girl said: *But just a little while ago you were green. And now you are gray.*

"The chameleon said: *Yes. Because I was on a leaf. Now I am on a stone.*

"The girl thought about this. She said: *But you used to be green. And now that part of you is gone. The green part is gone.*

"And the chameleon said: *No. The green part is still in me. It is just that I am the gray part now. Tomorrow I will be on the brown trunk of a tree, and I will be brown. And the green part will still be in me. And the gray part. And the brown part. I will be all my parts. I am the one who changes. That is who I am.*"

The grandmother paused. She looked around at the children.

"You see, my hearts? The chameleon is not telling her that change is small. The chameleon is telling her that change is *who he is*. The chameleon is everyone the chameleon has ever been, and everyone

the chameleon will be. The chameleon contains all the chameleons.

"The girl was quiet a long time. She watched the chameleon. After a while she said: *I do not want to be like you.*

"And the chameleon said: *You are like me. Everyone is. Even the river. Even the baobab. Even the moon, who is sometimes round, and sometimes thin, and sometimes gone. Everyone changes. The only difference is whether you change with grace or with grief.*

"The girl said: *I am very afraid I will lose myself.*

"And the chameleon — and this is the part I want you to remember, my hearts — the chameleon said:

"*You cannot lose yourself. The self is the thing that does the changing. The river is not less of a river because it flows. The river is the river* because *it flows. If it stopped, it would be a pond. And you can be a pond, if that is what you want. But you are a river. So flow.*"

The grandmother stopped.

The smallest child, in the front, said: "Did she?"

"She did."

"She grew up?"

"She did."

"Did she still love the river?"

"She loved the river. And she loved her brothers, who became men with families. And she loved her own mother, who became old. And she loved the village, which became different. And she loved her own children, whom she had. And she loved her own old self — the girl she had been — who was still in her, like all the colors of the

chameleon."

The grandmother smiled.

"And do you know what? Many years later, when she was an old woman, and she was the storyteller of her village, she was telling this story to her own grandchildren. And while she was telling it, she felt something move on the stool beside her. She looked.

"There was a chameleon on the stool. Green. Just like the one by the river.

"Maybe it was the same chameleon. Maybe it was not. Chameleons do not live as long as people, so probably it was not. But she said to her grandchildren — and she meant it: *we do not lose the people we were. We become them. Every one. Carry them with you.*"

The grandmother let out a long, slow breath.

"That is the story of the girl and the chameleon. Tomorrow night I will tell you the story of the lion and the small frog who taught him to dance. Now go and eat your supper."

The children groaned. Then they got up and ran.

The clearing emptied.

The grandmother stayed where she was, on her low stool, looking at the fire.

After a while, without looking up, she said quietly:

"You may come down, if you like, owl."

Story froze.

The grandmother kept looking at the fire.

"I know you have been there for several days. I have seen your shadow over the baobab. I have heard you, the way I hear things. You are welcome. There is mealie meal and a little goat. You may have a piece if you like."

Story did not move at first.

Then — very slowly — she flew down from the mango tree and landed on the corner of the grandmother's stool.

The grandmother looked at her.

Her eyes were ancient. They were the eyes of someone who had been telling stories for so long that there was almost nothing left in her that was not story.

She looked at the marks. Each one. She took her time.

"Many," she said.

"Yes."

"And you keep gathering."

"I do."

The grandmother smiled.

"You are the chameleon yourself. Did you know? You are the chameleon yourself. You have been every color you have ever been, and you are wearing all of them at once."

Story felt the warmth come.

It came on the sides of her face, just below the bronze ovals behind her eyes. Small, quick, sure. She knew without looking what

it would be. She felt the shape of it.

Two small chameleons. One on each cheek. Tails curled. Eyes — even in the marking — looking different directions, the way real chameleons can. The mark of a story about change.

The grandmother looked at them, and laughed — a small, soft, satisfied laugh.

"There you are," she said. "Now you have me too."

She reached out and gently touched the bead string at Story's throat. The faded beads from the singing woman of the high mountains.

"Whoever gave you these," the grandmother said, "would be glad. Tell her, if you see her again. Tell her: a storyteller in Mozambique met her gift. The gift travels."

Story bowed her head.

The grandmother got up. She went into her hut. She came back with a piece of dried goat, which she set on the ground beside the stool. She nodded once to Story. Then she went back into her hut, and the door closed behind her.

Story stayed by the fire for a long time, eating the goat slowly. The night sounds came up — crickets, frogs, a distant drum in the larger building down the way.

She thought: *I am the chameleon. I am every color I have ever been. I am every story. I am the river that flows, and that is why I am still a river.*

She thought of her family in the far forest, who would be old by now. Her mother. Her father. The brothers in their territories. Her grandmother, who could not see and who heard marks landing.

She would visit them. Soon.

She had stopped aging, but they had not. And the chameleon was right — flowing was who she was, but flowing meant you had to keep going *toward* the people you loved, not only away.

She finished the goat.

She climbed back into the great baobab to sleep, with the small chameleons new on her cheeks, and the standing stones on her back, and all the rest of her — and she slept the way a river sleeps, which is to say not at all, but going on, gently, in the dark.

End of Chapter Fourteen.

Chapter Fifteen: The Cape

She flew south down the eastern shore of Africa for many days.

The land below changed slowly. The grasslands became drier. The trees became smaller, scattered, then disappeared entirely. The sea grew rougher. The colors of the country shifted from warm gold and green to a stark gray-blue, the colors of stone and cold water and the kind of sky that has been blown clean by wind.

She crossed a long peninsula that thrust out into the ocean like a great pointing finger. Mountains rose along its spine — tall, sharp, dark. At their southern tip, the land simply ran out, and there was only the meeting of two great oceans, churning against each other in white foam.

She had heard about this place. The fishermen on the eastern coast had spoken of it.

The Great Cape.

She flew along the western side of the peninsula, low, watching the coast. There were small coves of pale sand. Boulders of pink granite tumbled into the sea. Kelp moved in dark forests just under the waves. The wind, even in summer, had a bite to it.

She was looking for a particular place. A place she had heard about. A small beach.

She found it just before sunset.

A long curve of pale sand sheltered between two great granite headlands. Boulders the size of houses. And on the beach, on the rocks, in the kelp, everywhere she looked —

Penguins.

She had never seen penguins before.

There were hundreds of them.

They were small — smaller than she would have guessed — and round, and shaped like little black-and-white drops of water. They had pink markings above their eyes. They stood in clusters. They wandered into the surf and emerged again. They argued with each other in loud bray-like calls that did not sound like anything she had heard a bird make before.

Some of them were caring for chicks — fluffy gray puffballs that sat patiently on the sand while their parents brought them small silver fish from the sea.

Story landed on a rock above the beach, very quietly, and watched.

She had seen many kinds of birds in her travels. She had seen condors that rode the wind for days, and tiny hummingbirds, and pelicans that flew in V-formations, and storks that nested on roofs. She had seen all the kinds of birds she had thought there were.

She had not, in all her travels, seen birds that could not fly.

It was strange to watch.

The penguins were *birds*. She could see that. They had feathers, beaks, wings. But the wings were small, and shaped like fins, and they did not flap. The penguins used them for balance when they walked, and for fast swimming when they dove. But they did not lift them and go.

They walked. They waddled. They tumbled over rocks. They stood for long minutes looking at the sea, the way she might stand for long minutes looking at the sky.

She thought: *what would it be like, to be a bird who does not fly?*

She had been watching for some time when she noticed two humans coming carefully down a wooden boardwalk above the beach.

They were old. Both of them. The kind of old where you walk with care, where each step is chosen, where you take your time.

The man was tall and somewhat stooped, with a great white beard. He wore a wide-brimmed hat and carried a pair of binoculars on a strap around his neck. He had the look, Story thought, of a person who had spent his whole life looking at things very carefully.

The woman beside him was small and bright-eyed. Her hair was silver and short. She held the man's elbow as they came down the boardwalk — not because either of them needed help, but in the way of two people who had walked together for a very long time.

They reached a wooden bench halfway down and sat on it, slowly. The man set down a small bag he had been carrying. The woman straightened her glasses on her nose.

They looked, in silence, at the penguins.

After a long while, the woman said:

"Well, Pappy. There they are."

"There they are, Suze."

"How does it feel?"

The man did not answer at first. He raised the binoculars to his eyes and looked at the penguins. He lowered them. He looked at his wife.

"It feels," he said, "like a thing being finished."

"Eighteen species, dear."

"Eighteen species."

"In — what is it now? Forty-something years?"

"Forty-three."

She laughed quietly. "Forty-three years."

"Tomorrow it will be forty-four."

"Yes. Tomorrow it will."

They sat. The sun was getting low. The penguins were arguing about something, somewhere down the beach.

"The grandkids are going to be furious that we did this without them," she said.

"Georgie won't mind. Georgie's six. She'll just want to see the photos."

"It's Ben who'll be angry."

"Oh, *furious*. Ben is *furious*. The boy has not forgiven me for the Galápagos last year."

She laughed and leaned her shoulder gently against his. After a moment he took her hand.

"We'll bring them," he said. "When they're old enough. Ben to Antarctica — he'd lose his mind in Antarctica — and Georgie to wherever Georgie decides she wants to go."

"Probably here. She'd love these."

"She would."

They were quiet a long time.

Then the woman said: "Eighteen species, Pappy. There's nothing left for you to chase."

The man squeezed her hand.

"Yes there is, Suze."

"What?"

"You. You're always next on the list."

She laughed and pretended to hit his arm. They sat that way — hand in hand, watching the penguins — until the sun was nearly down.

Story watched them for a long time, perched on her rock above the beach. She did not entirely know why she could not stop watching them. Perhaps because she had spent so many years now watching other creatures complete things, and there was something about watching two humans complete something so quietly that touched her.

Then a voice from below her said: "You are a long way from home, friend."

She looked down.

A penguin was standing at the base of her rock, looking up.

The penguin was old. Story could see this. Its feathers were a little ragged at the edges. The pink mark above its eyes was paler than the pink on the younger ones. Its eyes were calm and very dark.

"How did you know I am from a long way?" she said.

The penguin nodded its small black head, slowly. "Owls do not live by my sea. I have lived a long time, and I have not seen one. Therefore, you are from a long way."

"I am."

"And you carry many marks. I see them, even in this light."

"I do."

"Will you come down? I would like to see them properly."

Story flew down. She landed on the sand, awkwardly — it was the first time she had stood on a beach. The penguin walked closer with the rolling waddle of penguins. Its feet were pink and webbed.

It looked her over carefully. It tilted its head this way and that, the way Story herself tilted her head when she was thinking.

"Beautiful," it said finally. "Beautiful, beautiful. Where have you been, friend?"

"Everywhere."

"How long?"

"A long time."

"And still going?"

"Still going."

The penguin nodded slowly. It looked, for a moment, toward the bench where the two humans sat.

"My friends and I get many visitors here," it said. "Most of them human. Some of them taller than that man, with cameras. Some of them shorter. But all of them — all of them — have a thing they are doing. They are coming to the end of something. They walk down that boardwalk a little slower than the people behind them. Most of them, in their lives, have come to see us last."

"Last?"

"Last of the penguins. There are eighteen of us, you understand. In the world. Eighteen kinds. We are the easiest to reach. The ones in the Antarctic are very far. The ones in the Galápagos are very hot. We are the simplest. The kindest gate to come through. So we are very often the last."

Story looked at the bench. The man and woman were still there.

"Them," she said quietly.

"Them. Yes. I have been watching them. I have watched their kind for many years. You can tell. There is a stillness about them. A kind of completion. They are saying a quiet goodbye to one of their own dreams."

The penguin paused.

"That is one of the saddest things in the world, friend. It is also one of the most beautiful."

"Would you like me to tell you a story?" the old penguin said. "We have one, here on this cape. We have had it for many

generations. It was first told to us by a grandmother from one of the villages above — the African people who lived along this coast for thousands of years before any other people came. She told it to my grandfather's grandfather. We have been telling it back ever since."

"What is it about?"

"A journey. About how we got here."

Story sat down on the sand. She folded her wings. The sun was nearly at the water now. The two humans on the bench were silhouetted against the gold.

"Please," she said.

"A very long time ago," the old penguin began, "before any of this — before this cape was a cape, before there were villages above us, before there were even any of you owls watching from rocks — all the birds in the world could fly.

"All of them. The ones with great wings. The ones with small wings. The ones with feathers like fans and the ones with feathers like daggers. Even my ancestors. We flew too. We flew with the others. We were tall, then, and our wings were broad, and we could climb as high as any of the eagles.

"The world was full of birds. Maybe too full. There were so many birds in the sky that the sun was darkened with them when they all rose at the same time. There were arguments. There were collisions. The big ones ate the small ones. The fast ones outflew the slow ones. The sky was a hard place to live, sometimes.

"My ancestors lived along this very coast. They flew up and down it, fishing. They argued with the gulls and the cormorants. They competed for the same fish. It was a tiring life.

"And one of them — one bird, an ancestor whose name we have forgotten — looked down one evening at the water, and noticed something.

"The water was full.

"Not just at the top, where the gulls dipped. Not just where the cormorants dove. *All the way down*. The water was full of fish, layer after layer, deeper and deeper, into a darkness no bird had ever flown through.

"And the ancestor thought: *what if we went there?*"

The old penguin paused.

"He went to a council of birds. He stood before them. He said: *I have been watching the sea. The sea is full of fish. Fish enough for all of us. We have been crowding the sky for nothing.*

"And the birds laughed at him. They said: *the sea is for swimmers, not for birds. We are sky creatures. The water is cold. We would freeze. We would drown.*

"And our ancestor said: *We have feathers. Feathers keep us warm. We could grow more of them, thicker, denser. We have wings. Wings can be shaped differently. We could shape them for water, not for air. We could push through water the way we push through air.*

"And the birds laughed harder. They said: *and then you would not be able to fly anymore. Don't you see? You cannot have both. You cannot have the wings of the air and the wings of the sea. If you*

change one, you lose the other. The wings work one way or the other way. Not both.

"And our ancestor said: *I would lose the sky to gain the sea.*

"The birds stopped laughing.

"They said: *you cannot be serious. The sky is everything. The sky is what birds are for. You would give up the sky?*

"And our ancestor said: *Yes. I would give it up for the deep. Look. I have seen the deep. None of you have. I have looked at it for hours. It is bigger than the sky. It is darker. It has things in it the sky does not have. Whole forests of weed. Mountains under the water. Creatures with their own light. I want to see those things. I want to live among them. The sky is bright, but the sea is bigger.*

"The old eagle who led the council said: *Once you go, you cannot come back. The gift is given once.*

"And the ancestor said: *I know.*

"So the ancestor walked down to the sea. He stepped into the water. The cold of it was terrible. He took a breath. He folded his wings to his sides. He pushed off, into the surf.

"And his body began to change.

"His wings became smaller. Denser. Heavier. Better at pushing through water. His feathers thickened. His bones became solid. His fat became thicker. His body became shaped like a small black-and-white tear-drop, for cutting through the cold.

"And he learned, in that first hour, that there was indeed a kind of flight under the water. A flight no bird had ever known. He could go down and down, and the dark of the water embraced him, and the

fish were everywhere, and his small new shape moved through it like an arrow.

"He came up. He looked at the sky. The sky was very far away now. The other birds were small specks. He waved a flipper at them.

"They did not wave back. They did not understand what he had done.

"But the sea understood. The sea welcomed him. And he stayed.

"And his children stayed. And their children. And their children. And here we are, friend. On this beach. Where we have been, in one form or another, since that first ancestor stepped into the cold water and said yes to the sea."

The penguin was quiet a moment.

"And the grandmother who told us this story said, when she was done telling it: *the world is large, my children. It has many homes. You can have one home, or the other. You cannot have both. So choose. Choose the home that is yours. Choose the home that calls you. And do not look back at the home you did not choose, except with kindness. Because you could not have been everywhere. Nobody can.*"

Story was quiet a long time.

Below the rocks, in the gathering dusk, the penguins were calling to each other.

"That is a beautiful story," she said.

"It is."

"Did your ancestor ever regret it?"

The old penguin tilted its head.

"My grandfather's grandfather, who first heard the story from the village grandmother, said this: *one night each year, on the night when the moon is brightest, every penguin who is alive will come up onto the rocks. They will not eat. They will not fight. They will not call to each other. They will sit, all of them, all night, and they will look up at the sky.*"

"They are remembering."

"Yes. They are remembering being able to fly. And in the morning they will turn around and go back to the sea, because the sea is theirs and they would not give it up for anything. But once a year, they look up. Once a year, they remember."

The penguin looked at her.

"You will understand. I think. Because you have given things up too."

"I have."

"What did you give up, friend?"

Story thought about it.

"A nest in a tall fir. A mother. A father. Two brothers in their own territories. A mate I never had. Owlets I will never have. A simple kind of being an owl. I gave that up to be what I became."

"And was it worth it?"

She looked up at the bench, where the two humans sat hand in hand in the last light.

"It was. It is. But sometimes — "

"Sometimes you look up."

"Yes."

"All travelers do, friend. Every one of us. That is the price of having chosen."

She felt the warmth come.

It came on her sides, low — just where her body met her legs, the place where penguins are widest. A small heat on each side. Then it stilled.

She knew the shape before she looked.

Two small penguins. Mirrored. Standing upright. One on each hip. Tiny, neat, distinct.

The old penguin looked at them and ducked its head, formally.

"Welcome to the company of penguins, friend. You are one of us now. Whether you want to be or not."

Story laughed. It was the first time she had laughed in a long time.

Up on the bench, the man stirred.

He had been silent for a long time. His wife had been silent too. They were watching the penguins, and they were watching the sea, and they were holding hands.

But now the man slowly raised his binoculars.

He had seen something.

He looked through them for a long moment.

Then he lowered them, slowly, and he turned to his wife.

"Suze."

"Yes."

"Look at that owl."

"What owl?"

"On the sand. By the penguin. There. Look. Just look."

The woman lifted her own binoculars. She was quiet a long time.

Then she said: "Pappy. That owl is — "

"Yes."

"Are those — "

"I think so."

"What — what is — "

"I have no idea what it is. I have never seen anything like it."

They watched, the two of them, for a long time.

The woman lowered her binoculars. She put one hand on her husband's arm.

"You know what, Pappy."

"What."

"That isn't on the list."

The man laughed.

"No, Suze. That isn't on the list."

They watched until Story rose — until she shook out her wings, looked once more at the old penguin, looked once toward the bench where the two humans sat, and rose up off the sand into the darkening air.

She climbed.

She turned around the point of the great cape, and disappeared from view.

The man lowered his binoculars.

"What was it?" his wife said.

"I don't know. I don't think anyone knows."

"Then how did *we* get to see it?"

The man thought about this for a long time. Then he said: "We came a long way, Suze. People who come a long way sometimes see things that aren't on lists."

She laughed. She leaned against his shoulder.

The sun finished its long slow falling. The sea turned black. The penguins on the beach below began to settle for the night, the chicks tucked beneath their parents, the old penguin who had told the story standing alone for a moment longer on the sand, looking up at the sky where the first stars were coming out.

It was not the night of the brightest moon. But for one long beat, the old penguin remembered anyway.

And far above the cape, on her long flight onward, Story did the same.

End of Chapter Fifteen.

Chapter Sixteen: The Garden

Story flew north and east.

She crossed the warm sea where dhows with curved sails crossed below her, and small fishing boats, and once a great oil tanker creeping along the horizon. She crossed dry coast, and inland desert. She crossed a strait, and another strait, and a sea, and at last she was over land again, dry red land that stretched on and on, broken by small green river valleys and walled cities with domes.

She kept going.

She crossed a wide brown river. She crossed a great fertile plain. The land softened. The trees thickened. The rivers ran milky-pale with the first runoff of mountains she could now see in the distance, vast and white. The air had the smell of warm dust and ripe fruit and old smoke and the spices of cooking.

She was in India.

She landed in a banyan tree on the edge of a small town, and rested.

She had not chosen to come here, exactly. She had simply followed where her wings took her. There was a story in her that she did not yet have. She felt it the way she had felt the pull of the wind in the very first night of her life, when she lay under her mother's wing and heard the distant voices of the world.

She had not felt that pull in a long time.

She rested for a day. Then she flew on, north, into the foothills of the great mountains.

She came, on the third evening, to a small clearing in a forest of teak and bamboo.

In the clearing was a small monastery.

It was very simple. A low rectangular building of mud-brick, painted white, with a thatched roof. A wooden door, open. A small stupa — a dome of white-washed stone — at the side. A pond. A garden with rows of long-leafed vegetables. A single old peepal tree, broad and dark, in the middle of the clearing.

Beneath the peepal tree, an old monk in saffron robes was sitting on a mat. Around him, in a half-circle, sat several boys — five of them, perhaps — in similar saffron robes, with their heads shaved. The smallest was perhaps six. The oldest was perhaps thirteen.

The monk was speaking.

Story landed in the peepal tree, in the higher branches where she would not be seen, and listened.

"... and today, my children, I will tell you again the story of how he came into the world. Not because you have not heard it. You have heard it many times now. But every time we tell a great story we hear it differently. So we will tell it again. And we will see what we hear today.

"In a kingdom not very far from here — not far at all, in fact, just north of this forest — there once lived a king and a queen.

"The king's name was Suddhodana. He was a good king. He had ruled his small mountain kingdom for many years, with wisdom and

care. His people loved him. He had everything a king could want.

"Everything except one thing.

"He and his queen had no child.

"They had been married a long time. They had hoped, year after year, for a baby. None had come. The king was beginning to be afraid that he would die with no one to take the throne after him.

"His queen was Maya. She was kind. She was quiet. She loved her husband, and she loved her gardens, and she loved the small things — the birds at the windows, the colors of the morning, the way the rain sounded on the roof tiles. She was not a queen who needed great things. She had been content for years to be the queen without being a mother.

"But she also wanted a child.

"And one summer night, while the king and queen were sleeping in their pavilion, Queen Maya had a dream.

"In the dream, the moon was full and white over her garden. The night was very quiet. And then, from out of the sky, came a white elephant.

"The elephant was small — small enough to fit through her window, which it did. It had six tusks. It glowed faintly, like the moon itself. It walked into her room without making any sound. It walked toward the queen, and it touched her gently on her side. And then it walked back out the window, into the sky, and disappeared into the moon.

"Queen Maya woke up.

"She woke the king. She told him the dream. She was trembling, and she did not know why.

"In the morning the king called for the wise men of his court. He told them the dream. The wise men listened carefully, and then they bowed, very low, to the queen.

"And they said: *Your majesty. The dream means a great thing. Your son is coming. He will be a great man. He will be either a great king — the greatest of all kings — or he will be a great holy man, the kind who comes to the world only once in many ages. The choice will be his.*"

The monk paused. The boys were very still.

"And in the proper season, Queen Maya knew she was going to have a baby. The king was overjoyed. The whole kingdom rejoiced. The queen was treated like the most precious creature in the world. She was given silk pillows. She was fed only the softest fruit. She was walked, very slowly, in her favorite garden, every morning.

"And when her time was nearly come, she asked her husband if she might travel to her parents' home, far to the east, to have the baby with her mother by her side. The king agreed.

"They set out — the queen and her ladies and a small company of guards — in a great procession with banners.

"They did not get there.

"On the third day of their journey, the queen felt the baby coming. They were passing through a small grove of sal trees. The grove was called Lumbini.

"The procession stopped. The queen got down from her palanquin. She walked, slowly, into the grove. The trees were in bloom — pale flowers, with a smell like honey. The queen reached up — for the queen was small, and she felt suddenly that she wanted to hold something — and she took hold of a low branch of a sal tree. She held on. She breathed deeply. The branch was warm in her hand.

"And there, standing in the grove, holding the branch, with her ladies all around her, she had her baby.

"He came easily. There was no pain. The story says he came smiling.

"The ladies caught him in soft cloth. They washed him in warm water. They put him in the queen's arms.

"And the baby — and this is the part you have heard a hundred times, my children, but I am going to tell you again — the baby opened his eyes."

The monk's voice went very quiet.

"The baby opened his eyes and looked around. And then, although he was only a few minutes old, he sat up. He looked at his mother. He looked at the ladies. He looked at the sky.

"And then he climbed out of his mother's arms.

"He stood up. On legs that had never been used.

"And he walked. *Seven steps*. Slow, careful, deliberate. One step. Two. Three. Four. Five. Six. Seven.

"And wherever his small foot touched the earth, a lotus opened. Out of the dust of the road, where there had never been a lotus before. Pink, with golden hearts. A lotus for each step. Seven lotuses,

in a perfect line, marking where he had walked.

"And then the baby stopped. He turned. He looked back at his mother.

"And he said — and they say it was the only thing he ever said as a baby, because after that he was just a baby again, the way all of us are babies after birth — he said:

"*This is my last time. I have come to wake the world.*

"And then he sat down on the grass, and he was a baby again, and he cried for milk."

The monk was quiet a moment.

"The procession turned around. They did not continue to the queen's parents' house. The queen needed to rest, and the baby — well. The baby needed quiet.

"They brought him back to the palace. And the king came to see his son. The king picked him up. The king looked at this tiny boy who had walked seven steps on lotuses, and who had spoken once and would not speak again for many seasons. And the king — who was a king, and who loved his small kingdom, and who did not want a holy man for a son but a king to come after him — the king made a decision.

"He said: *my son will be a king. The greatest king. Not a holy man.*

"He named the baby Siddhartha. *He whose purpose will be fulfilled.* He kept the name, even though the name had two meanings, and both of them were true.

"And the king decided that his son would never see anything that was sad. *Never*. Because he had heard, deep in his bones, what the wise men had said. *Great king or great holy man.* The king knew what made men into holy men. It was sadness. It was the seeing of sadness. It was the knowing of how the world was. The king believed — and he had a kind of point — that if his son never saw the sad things, his son would never become a holy man. His son would stay a happy prince, and become a happy king, and rule a happy kingdom, and that would be that.

"So the king built his son a world.

"He built three great pleasure-palaces — one for summer, one for winter, one for the rainy season. He filled them with everything good. Music. Flowers. Soft cloth. Fruit. Lovely young people, all of them young, all of them healthy, all of them happy. He surrounded his son with gardens of singing birds and pools of bright fish. He never let his son see the village beyond the walls. He never let his son meet anyone who was sick. He never let his son see an old face — even the gardeners were chosen for their youth, and they were quietly replaced before they showed any age. He never let his son meet death. When an animal died in the gardens, it was removed in the night. When a servant became unwell, that servant was sent away. When a leaf yellowed, the leaf was clipped before the prince saw it.

"It was a perfect world.

"In that world, the boy grew up.

"He grew up happy. He grew up kind. He grew up loved. He played. He learned to read. He learned to ride. He learned the arts a prince learns. He had friends. He had nothing to be unhappy about,

because no one had ever shown him that there was anything to be unhappy about.

"For many years, this worked.

"For many years, the prince did not know.

"He thought all the world was the way his world was. He thought everybody was young. He thought everybody was healthy. He thought nobody, anywhere, was ever sad.

"He was, the storytellers say, the most loved and the most ignorant boy who had ever lived."

The monk paused.

"And tomorrow night, when you sit with me again, I will tell you what happened the first day he left the palace. Now drink your tea and go to bed. The smallest of you is already asleep."

The smallest novice was indeed asleep, slumped against the knee of the boy beside him.

The others laughed quietly and got up. The monk gathered the mat. They all walked back toward the small mud-brick building, the smallest one lifted onto the shoulders of the largest, his bald little head bobbing against the night.

The lamps in the monastery went on, one by one, and then went out, one by one. The night came down.

Story stayed in the peepal tree.

She thought about what she had heard.

She thought about the seven lotuses, marking the small steps of a baby who would later wake the world.

She thought about the king. The father who had tried to build a world without sadness, because he loved his son too much to give him any.

She thought about her own father — Cedar — who, when she had been very small, had also worried about her. Who had wanted to keep her in the nest. Who had eventually said *you should go and see your grandmother*, when keeping her at home stopped being the right thing.

She thought about how love had to learn, again and again, to let things be hard.

The warmth came.

It came on her feet. On the very tops of her two clawed owl feet, where the feathers ended and the scales began. A small heat on each foot.

She did not need to look. She knew the shape already.

Two small lotuses. One on each foot. Open. With many petals, and a small golden heart at the center. Lotuses for the seven steps. For the prince who would later wake. For the king who had not yet learned. For her own father, who had.

She felt them settle.

And then she heard, from the small monastery below, the smallest of the novices murmuring in his sleep. And the old monk shifting on his mat, and turning over, and beginning to snore very gently.

She listened to the sound of breathing for a long time.

She did not fly on that night.

She would stay, she thought. She would stay until the monk had told the rest of it.

She had only heard the first part.

In the morning, the small novices came out of the monastery and began their day. They drew water from the pond. They fed the chickens. They tended the garden. The old monk sat in the doorway and watched them and called out small instructions when one of them did something foolish.

Story watched from the peepal tree.

The youngest novice — the one who had fallen asleep during the story — looked up at her in the late morning, and saw her, and his eyes went very wide.

He did not call to anyone. He did not point. He stood quite still under the tree, looking up.

Story looked back down at him.

After a long moment, the small novice raised one hand. Just a small wave. Then he turned around and ran back to his chores.

Story settled deeper into the peepal tree.

She would stay.

Tonight there would be more.

End of Chapter Sixteen.